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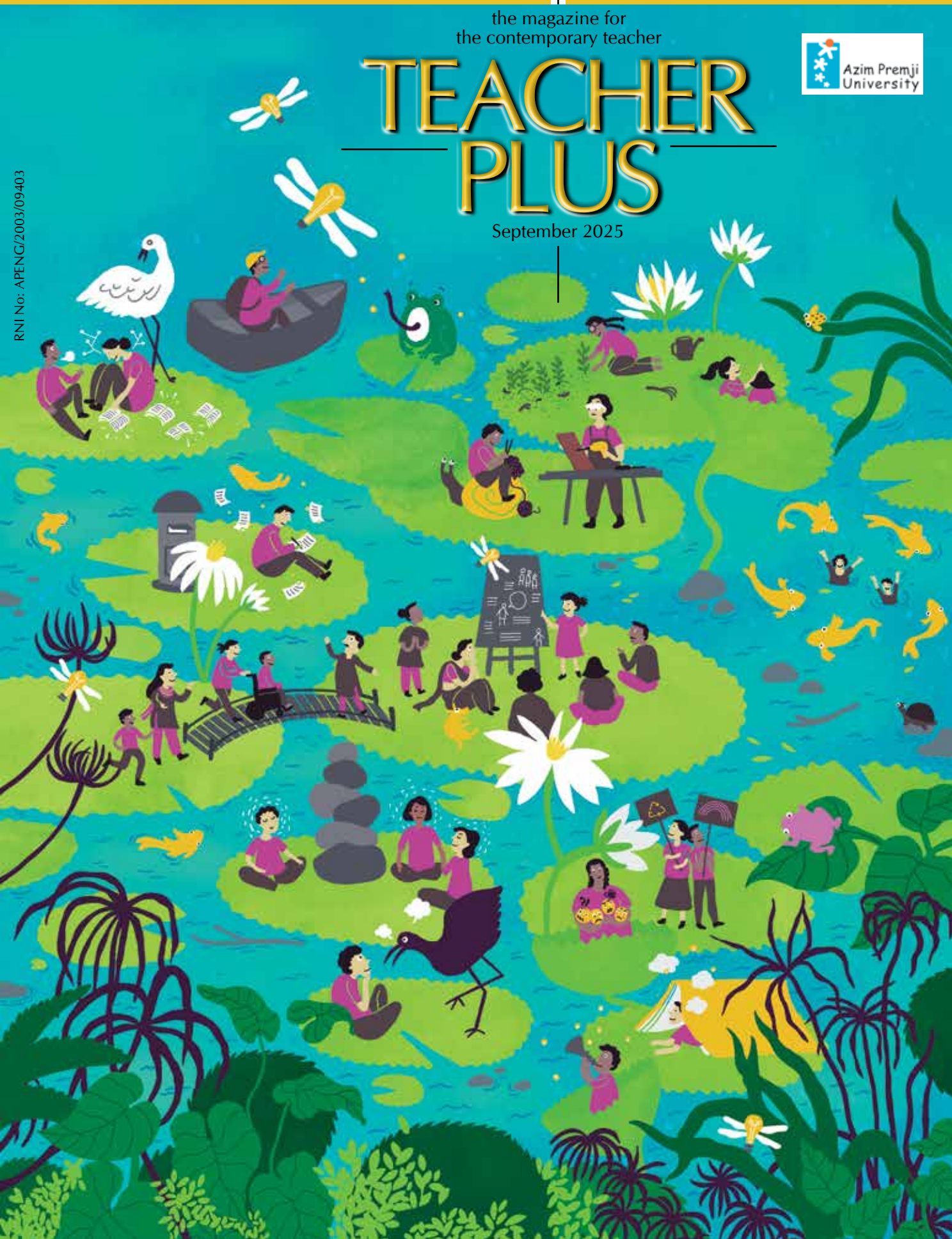

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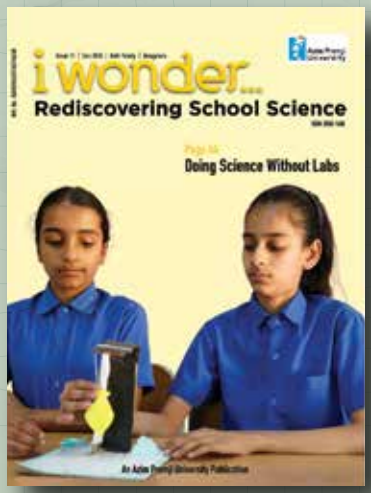

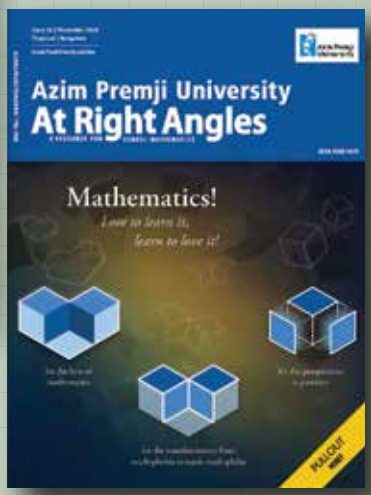

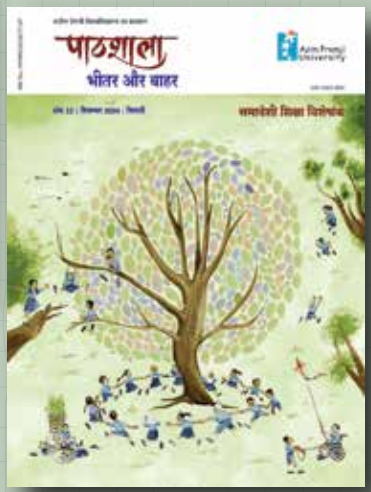

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EDITORIAL

If you can think it...

"Future thinking" is a term that's often employed these days in policy circles, think tanks, and research laboratories. It's also used a lot in the technology world, when imagining new tools for emergent needs – or needs that have not yet been felt. Sometimes referred to as "futures thinking" (in the plural), it can take a systematic and rule-based approach to construct scenarios and build trajectories to achieve them or change them. It requires imagination and the ability to speculate, but also the skill of seeing pathways and how to achieve the desired future, or in some cases, how to avoid a negative scenario that seems to be looming. Climate change activists and environmentalists for instance try to think about what would happen if we continued destroying our habitat at our current rate, and then work backwards to figure out how we might avoid or better manage, a catastrophe.

But wouldn't you agree that teaching is – or should be – a project of making the future? Day after day in our classrooms, we are working with young minds so that they can be ready for the world when they step out into it. Even when we are dealing with subjects that explain the world as it is, or as it has come to be, the point is to equip them with the understanding and skills that will help them occupy that world and remake it in better ways. The classroom is, of course, embedded within a complex and ever-changing ecology, and thinking about the future cannot disregard the problems of our present. Ultimately, it's a careful combination of recognizing where we are (pragmatism), seeing where we want to go (idealism), and thinking about how we get there, given our strengths and challenges (strategy). So, for us as teachers, it involves staying in touch with what is happening in our respective fields and in society, and making our teaching relevant in ways that can serve children both the present and the future. Yes, there is exam-directed work, but there also needs to be skilling and mindset building for resilience and adaptability. I find that it's useful, now and then, to stop what we are doing and just loosen our minds with what is often called "blue sky thinking". Ask yourself, what is the kind of future I want? Allow yourself to fantasize about this perfect world, indulging in painting the smallest details. Then pull back and think about what needs to be done in the present to achieve at least some part of it. Is there something here that can trickle down to what and how you teach?

But for now: ***Happy Teacher's Day!***

Usha Raman

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Change this and you

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Illustration: Shilpy Lather

Why is teaching regarded as an "anybody can do it" profession? Worse, it is frequently the last choice for a job seeker: *Didn't get the job of your choice? No worries, you can always become a teacher.*

It is THIS that I wish would change in our education system.

Teaching is a demanding job and should be accorded due respect (not only on Teacher's Day). Teaching is far more than transfer of prescribed content, or equipping students to succeed in the job market. As a teacher grows into her profession, she changes from within even as her students change her.

have changed it all

That the craft of teaching needs to be learnt, absorbed, immersed in, and allowed to slowly mature – how can our education system change so as to SEE this?

While I don't have a simple formula to enable this transformation, I can describe **indicators of a successful shift**:

- People who have never stepped into a classroom to teach will resist the temptation to advise a teacher how to teach. (Just as they will never tell a surgeon how to operate, or a lawyer how to win a case.)
- Policy makers will include practising teachers in their meetings and factor ground realities into the policies they make.
- Textbook writers will necessarily include practising teachers in their team of writers.
- Management institutes and companies who have never entered school education will realize that they are not equipped to offer programs to school teachers and principals on how to do their jobs better.
- Edtech companies will co-opt teachers into the development of their products instead of bypassing them totally as they now do.
- Teacher preparation programs will not be the ultimate learning for a teacher. Instead, teachers will be seen as needing professional development all through their careers.
- No teacher will be asked to go on census duty, election duty or gathering data for government surveys. [Instead, other professionals can be offered this privilege for a change.]
- A teacher who finds her student needs to go for after-school tuition will sit up and realize that there is something deficient in her own teaching – and take immediate action to rectify this.
- School managements will begin to encourage teachers to voice their opinions, speak their minds and think critically. [Unless they do this, they will not be able to expect teachers to hone critical thinking in their students.]
- Teachers will be asked to choose their areas of development, instead of being forced to attend a mandatory set of annual workshops that may (not) align with their specific learning needs.
- Teachers will have schedules that allow them to regularly spend time learning new things. Keeping teachers in the learning mode is the best way to ensure vibrancy in a school.

That's my dream for a change in our education system. And I will settle even for four or five of these!

TP

Reimagining education for every learner

Photos courtesy: Sri Sarada Devi Vidya Kendra, Shivanahalli

Ranu Singh is Principal and **Geetha R** is Co-principal at Sri Sarada Devi Vidya Kendra, Shivanahalli, Bengaluru. They can be reached at principal@ssvk.in.

On this Teacher's Day, as we honour educators who shape minds and futures, there's perhaps no better time to ask ourselves a fundamental question: If we could change education, what would it be? This isn't merely an academic exercise – it's an urgent call to reimagine how we nurture the next generation.

The answer, increasingly clear from classrooms across the country, points toward a revolutionary shift: moving from standardized, traditional uniform education to personalized learning that recognizes and celebrates each student's unique strengths, interests, and ways of understanding the world.

The limitations of standardization

Walk into most classrooms today, and you'll see a familiar scene: rows of desks facing the front, students of the same age working through identical worksheets, moving in lockstep toward the same assessments. This industrial model of education, designed over the past two centuries, treats children like products on an assembly line – expecting uniform outcomes from wonderfully diverse human beings.

The casualties of this approach are evident everywhere. The agile learner who can't sit still is labelled disruptive. The creative thinker who sees problems differently is marked as struggling. The students whose brilliance shines in unexpected ways never get the chance to discover their gifts. Meanwhile, even those who succeed in this system often graduate as skilled test-takers but lack the critical thinking, creativity, and collaboration skills our complex world demands.

A vision for transformation

Imagine instead walking into a classroom where learning is alive with possibility. Here, students don't just receive information – they actively construct understanding through exploration, questioning, and discovery. The teacher moves fluidly between roles: sometimes a guide pointing toward new territories of knowledge, sometimes a coach helping students develop skills, sometimes simply a fellow learner exploring alongside them.

In this transformed classroom, assessment isn't something that happens to students – it's something they participate in. Instead of high-stakes tests that measure memorization, students demonstrate their learning through portfolios that showcase growth over time, projects that solve real community problems, and presentations that allow them to share their unique insights and perspectives.

Perhaps, most importantly, this classroom buzzes with authentic communication. Students have learned not just to talk, but to truly listen to each other. They engage in meaningful dialogue, build on each other's ideas and navigate disagreements with respect and curiosity. This single change – learning to communicate effectively – creates ripple effects throughout the school community, fostering understanding, empathy, and the kind of collaborative problem-solving our world desperately needs.

Examples of change

This vision isn't a utopian fantasy – it's happening right now in some schools around the globe. At Sri Sarada Devi Vidya Kendra, Shivanahalli, a small village close to the Bannerghatta National Park near Bengaluru, students spend less time on standardized testing and more time on collaborative projects that integrate multiple subjects. Consistent efforts prove that personalized, student-centered approaches can deliver academic excellence. They don't just learn science – they conduct research that contributes to real scientific understanding. In our school, a science teacher along with the 9th and 10th grade students brought out a mini booklet to identify and document wild mushrooms on our campus.

Positive practical steps for individual educators

Every teacher has the power to begin this transformation, even

within the existing constraints. The journey starts with small, intentional changes that prioritize students as whole human beings rather than as test scores.

Start with relationships. Before diving into the curriculum, invest time in truly knowing your students. What excites them? How do they learn best? What challenges do they face outside school? What are the social complexes at home? When students feel seen and valued, learning becomes possible in ways that surprise even veteran educators. Likith from 3rd grade was a brilliant boy. But, he had an irritating habit of coming up on his friends and beating them casually. His friends were not very appreciative of this habit. After a minor incident involving one of his friends, both Likith and his parents were given counselling sessions to try and rid him of his habit. Now in the 5th grade, he is the class leader.

Embrace student voice. Ask students what they're curious about. Let their questions drive some of your lesson planning. When learners have agency in their education, engagement soars. This doesn't mean abandoning standards – it means finding creative ways to meet those standards through student-driven exploration. Partha from the 8th grade was curious about flying kites. He designed his own kite and developed a flying technique that allowed him to fly his kite higher than the other kite flyers.

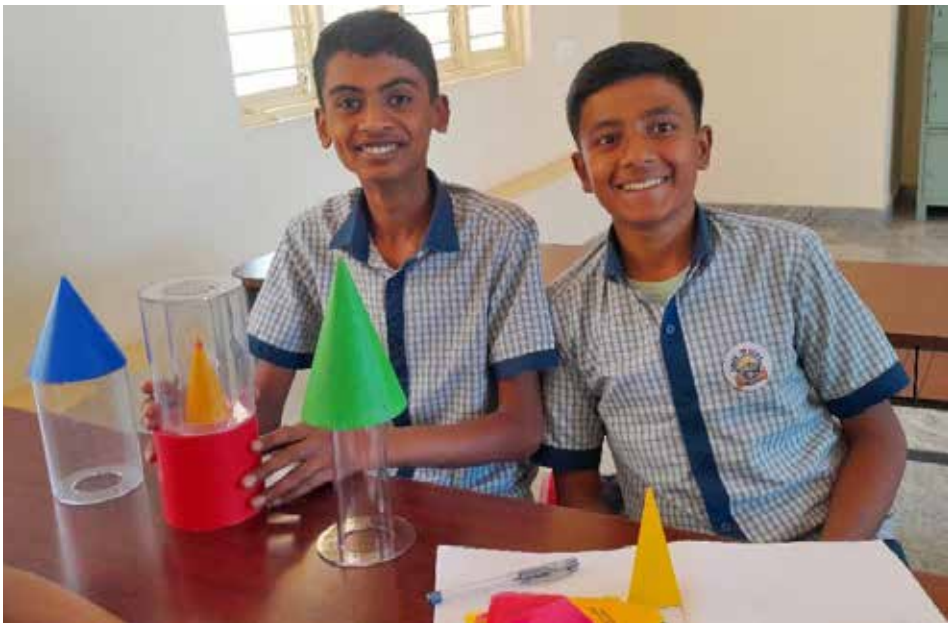
Diversify assessment. While you may still need to administer the required number of tests, look for additional ways in which students can demonstrate their learning. Can they create a video explanation? Build a model? Write a story? Lead a discussion? Interview their parents? The more pathways you provide, the more students can show what they truly understand. Thanushree from the 8th grade along with a small team of students made a documentary on saving Nature, thereby raising environmental consciousness on campus.

Focus on thinking, not just content. Instead of asking students to memorize facts, create an environment that will make them analyze, synthesize, and evaluate. Encourage them to ask good questions, not just find the right answers. These thinking skills will serve them long after they've forgotten the content. During a biology class, Saraswathi from the 6th grade asked about the creation and diversity of life, which led to a discussion on the various aspects of life, beauty of creation, colours, and classification.

Build a classroom community. Implement peer practices that will help students listen to and learn from each other. Morning meetings, peer feedback sessions, collaborative problem-solving activities and restorative circles all contribute to a culture where every voice matters. After an assessment in the 10th grade, peer correction helped students improve their writing skills.

Scaling systemic change

Individual classroom transformations are powerful, but lasting change requires systemic thinking. Schools and even boards



ready to embrace this shift must consider several key elements.

Professional development needs to focus less on program implementation and more on pedagogical understanding. Teachers need opportunities to explore child development, learning theory, and culturally responsive practices. They need time to collaborate, observe each other, and reflect on their practice. This seems to be the first crucial step.

Assessment systems must evolve beyond standardized testing. While accountability remains important, we need measures that capture growth, creativity, critical thinking, and social-emotional development. Portfolios, performance assessments, and student self-reflection can provide richer pictures of learning than any single test.

School structures often need fundamental reorganization. Rigid bell schedules, age-based groupings, and subject-area silos can all work against personalized learning. Schools exploring block scheduling, multi-age classrooms, and interdisciplinary teaching often find that structural changes enable pedagogical innovation.

Community engagement becomes crucial as schools move away from familiar models. Parents and community members need to understand why these changes matter and how they benefit students. When families see their children becoming more confident, creative, and engaged learners, they become powerful advocates for continued transformation.

The ripple effects of change

When education truly transforms, the benefits extend far beyond individual classrooms. Students who learn to think critically become citizens who can navigate complex social issues. Those who experience authentic collaboration become leaders who can work across differences. Young people who see their unique gifts valued become adults who contribute their talents to society.

These changes also reshape the teaching profession itself. When teachers become learning facilitators rather than information deliverers, their work becomes more creative, more responsive, and more professionally satisfying. Many educators report renewed passion for teaching when they shift to student-centered approaches.

Perhaps most importantly, transformed education creates more resilient communities. When schools become places where every child's voice matters, where differences are celebrated rather than standardized away, and where learning is joyful rather than anxiety-provoking, they become models for the kind of inclusive, collaborative society we need.

A call to action

Many instances remind us that education's purpose isn't to sort students into predetermined categories, but to help each learner discover and develop their unique gifts.

The question isn't whether change is needed – it's whether we have the collective will to make it happen. In classrooms, schools, and systems, educators are already proving that transformation is possible. They're showing us that when we trust students as partners in learning, honour their diverse ways of knowing, and create communities of care and challenge, education becomes what it was always meant to be: “the manifestation of the perfection already in man”. An ever relevant astounding idea by Swami Vivekananda.

As we celebrate teachers today, let's also commit to supporting them as agents of change. Let's ask not just what students need to learn, but how they learn best. Let's measure success not just by test scores, but by the confidence, creativity, and compassion our graduates carry into the world.

The future of education isn't waiting for permission – it's happening right now in the hands of dedicated educators who believe every child deserves to be seen, valued, and challenged to reach their full potential. This Teacher's Day, let's honour that vision by making it a reality, one classroom, one school, one community at a time.

TP

A quest

Jayanthi Sridhar is a Computer Science Facilitator at Sri Kumaran Children's Home – CBSE, Bengaluru. She has a strong interest towards self-care practices and earth sensitive living. She conducts gratitude journaling sessions, likes to write on sustainability issues and education. She can be reached at jayanthi.sridhar@kumarans.org or you can visit her website https://journalmuse.net to know more about her work.

The question, "If you could change education, what would it be? And why?" to a teacher becomes a quest. A quest to reflect on what's working well and what needs to change. A slew of issues – AI, dysfunctional families, climate crisis, unsafe environments, overdose of social media, easy access to the virtual world and money, and substance abuse – overwhelm children, throwing their lives out of gear. Addressing this at all levels is important for society to thrive and show collective progress.

An institution is more than a place of learning; it's a place where values are built, strengthened, and sustained for life.

This article is an attempt to capture solutions using time-tested techniques and borrowed inspiration. Strategies are aplenty; it is important to look at what is feasible within the framework of an institution.

Illustrations: Shilpy Lather

Clarity: Vision

It's imperative that schools have a clear vision and have the entire fraternity aligned to this vision. There are many ways this can be done. Spending time on each value with appropriate anecdotes taken from a school's growth chapter can be given as a talk or an activity-based workshop. Time should be given to absorb and understand the overall vision, and then the on-boarding process of teachers and parents can happen.

Alignment: Values

As individuals we all have a value system. It is necessary to know if our values align with the values of the school we work in, or where our children study. Schools can have a comprehensive session on nurturing values and relationships and on effective parenting styles a few times during the academic year.

The space: Layout

A school ideally must have trees, spaces that encourage gardening, soil, rooms suffused with natural light, and space for contemplation.

Ambience: Classroom

If there is flexibility to arrange furniture in the classroom according to the topic being studied, it might enhance learning. Groups of students can take up the responsibility of maintaining cleanliness and assisting the helpers and gardeners. Age-appropriate thought boards, reflective questions, and quiz questions with answers revealed after a few days can create a culture of critical thinking.

Classrooms can have desks with surfaces that can be written on with markers. Encourage students to use sketch notes to explain concepts. Classes can be taken outdoors twice during the day.

Learning: Curriculum

Teachers can be trained to be content creators and curriculum designers. Curriculum can be flexible depending on the class, and content can be made simpler or more challenging. Children should feel happy about their classes. There is often a mismatch between what we think is relevant and what actually works for children in their later years. We cannot predict the future; we can only prepare students to face challenges and think rationally with the excellent intuitive qualities they are already endowed with.

The curriculum can include activities that allow children to tap into their body's wisdom and the universal intelligence. For this, teachers have to undergo training in spirituality and not just academics.

Here's a beautiful instance of how a mentor nudges his students to observe while out in Nature: *"Do you feel that?" he asked, bouncing a little on his toes. "That sponginess underfoot? The humus here is extraordinary – millennia of decay. Imagine the rain of organic matter – needles, spores, twigs, and bugs building the soil from the top down. Photosynthesis – now isn't that a pure wonder, how light and air can end up as soil?"He liked to remind us that the genus Homo is derived from the Latin word for "humus" and for "humility." He was a humble man, a man of the soil who signed his name not with PhD appended, but as Francis D. Hole, TNS. It always drew the question, "Why TNS?"*

TNS is an acronym for Temporarily Not Soil.

The above paragraph is an excerpt from an essay that is part of a series shared in partnership with the Center for Humans and Nature, from their five-volume collection, *Elementals*.

Children and adults are disconnected from Nature and natural rhythms. This can be re-established by allowing them to play, observe, listen, and reflect upon this vital connection we all share.

When children are allowed to touch soil and grow a garden, there is reverence for that precious layer of earth – soil. When they use their hands to make or build something, their confidence levels rise.

Hands-on activities like craftwork, gardening, needlework, different painting styles, and pottery can be included in the curriculum to power their potential.

Judicious usage: Technology

Children are highly vulnerable and are exposed to unseen dangers more than ever.

Lateral and vertical reading can be taught to students so that they gain insights from multiple resources and use their discretion to analyze and reason about the information they receive. Spotting red flags in what they consume as content every day, preparing students to take control and use their sense of judgment rather than rely on influencers or AI algorithms to manage their opinions, and shaping their sense of style and wellbeing are what teachers can work on.

Allowing children to connect with Nature, revere all creations, and giving them adequate tools for mental health like breath-work, mindfulness, gratitude journaling, yoga, and free play is

vital. Grounding activities that are age-appropriate can be included, irrespective of the space available.

Schools that implement woodwork, weaving, and pottery by inviting experts and artisans show remarkable progress in thinking skills among students – their interactions with people improve as they understand that expertise takes years of dedication and perseverance.

Reading, writing, and recall can be revived in different formats. Reading spaces and book launches by students will encourage children to write and understand the efforts in organizing events and the need to slow down and experience time unplugged.

Peer-to-peer learning, and seniors and juniors learning from one another, can be included in the curriculum. Assessment for and by students using online tools will keep the students involved and engaged in the learning.

Leverage: Music

People tune into healing frequency music as a natural pathway to inner harmony. This ancient practice offers a fascinating intersection of science, sound, and therapeutic healing.

The chirping of birds, the rustling of leaves in the wind, or the falling rain are considered healing sounds. The frequencies of sound waves, measured in hertz (Hz), have healing properties.

The frequency of 528 Hz is believed to promote healing and repair at the cellular level, while a frequency of 432 Hz promotes balance and harmony. When healing frequencies are combined with music, the effects can be even more powerful.

Music classes or using music in classrooms and playing calming music in school buses might reduce anxiety levels and keep children happy.

Ancient texts like the Gandharva Veda (from the Vedic scriptures) and Raga Chikitsa elaborate on the healing properties of Indian music and the ability to raise consciousness and connect with the higher self.

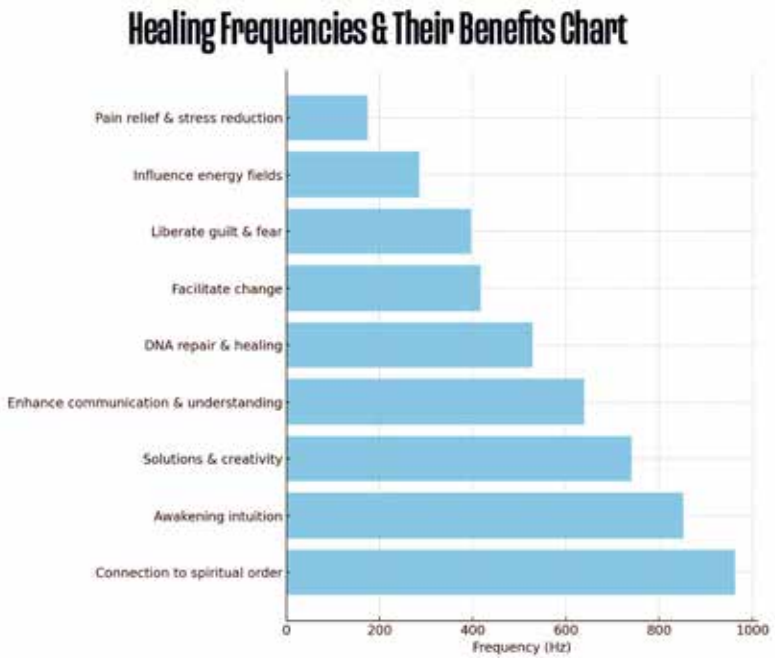


Image source: https://www.myrelaxation.online/healing-frequencies/

Culture: Mantras and affirmations

"Live your life by a compass, not a clock." – Stephen Covey.

Mantras strengthen focus and keep us grounded. Starting the day with a mantra, having students chant *Annapurne Sadaapurne* before food, and chanting the Shanthi Mantra at the end of the day are simple, doable practices that we follow in our school.

Simple affirmations such as, "I am committed to being mindful through my day," which students resonate with, can be introduced before they begin the day along with shlokas to reinforce good, positive thinking.

Showcase: Special assembly

Every performance on stage gives children the opportunity to showcase any creative pursuit. Special assembly programs can be entirely scripted by students as young as class 4! This allows them to be articulate and polish their talent and organizational skills.

Skills: Clubs

Diverse skills by professionals can be taught to students. When an array of choices like photography, nature journaling, poetry, and linguistics are given, students become aware and adept at more skills. Learning the use of herbs as natural remedies, reviving forgotten traditional recipes, and taking part in solving civic issues are a few activities that can be offered to children throughout the year.

Mindfulness: Celebrations

School events that celebrate student wins should include connecting with the earth. The materials we use for decorations, the posters, the gifts, and the cutlery can be earth-friendly and become the voice for promoting a sustainable lifestyle.

We need to help children navigate the world and the issues they face by helping ourselves learn, adapt, and unlearn. Children should have safe, non-judgmental, extremely supportive spaces that enable a growth mindset and help them identify their purpose on this planet.

Children should be taught how to treat and interact with elders, not feel awkward around them. Our country's ancient wisdom is as valuable as one can glean from it. To weave that wisdom in creative, scientific ways into the existing education system, currently a kaleidoscope of sorts, is the need of the hour. To empower children to reason, question, and, if necessary, disrupt obsolete norms and use their superpowers might sound fantastic. Yet, it is this optimistic view that drives teachers to come to school every day, sporting a smile, maneuvering through the emotions of young people, sensing the shift in how children learn, and still doing what's best and permissible.

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TP

Less is more

Rethinking education for a changing world

Vignesh Krishnan, Director of Global Expansion, Christel House International. Christel House is a global network of schools across five countries that delivers a comprehensive educational experience for children from socio-economically disadvantaged backgrounds. He can be reached at vignesh@christelhouse.org.

What is strikingly common between children studying in vastly different corners of India? Let's imagine the lives of two 15-year-olds – Saba, attending a private school in Bengaluru, Karnataka and Arjun, enrolled in a government school in Latehar, Jharkhand. Their classrooms, teachers, and daily realities may look nothing alike. But what they learn in school follows a similar pattern, a weight carried forward from past generations. The education system operates like a hoarder's house: nothing ever gets thrown away, everything just gets piled on top. If Priya or Arjun's grandparents learned about the Sepoy Mutiny of 1857 in the 1960s, their parents added computer awareness in the early 1990s. Now, they've inherited all of it plus environmental studies, plus value education, plus AI basics, among others.

This "do more, learn more" is so ingrained that not overloading kids just seems like a good wishlist that's never seen the light of the day for decades. But is all this 'more' actually helping children as they grow into young adults? We see worrying signs everywhere: Millions of highly educated youth remain underemployed or jobless. In 2018, over 93,000 candidates, including 3,700 PhD holders, applied for 62 peon jobs in Uttar Pradesh that required only a 5th grade education (Economic Times, 2018). Similarly, former RBI Governor Raghuram Rajan highlighted that 19 million people applied for 60,000 railway jobs (The Print, 2019).

Photos courtesy: Christel House International

Meanwhile, we are also witnessing teenagers without degrees launching startups and leading climate movements. A student who started a side-hustle at 16 turned it into a $3 million business by her early 20s (Entrepreneur, 2020). Who doesn't know about the impact 15-year-old Greta Thunberg had in kicking off a global youth climate activist movement. Gen Z and Gen Alpha are clearly eager to take on real-world challenges, but our education system seems stuck preparing them for a world that no longer exists.

The education-workforce disconnect

A glaring reality that is visible in the last few decades is that while there is a huge surge of academic degrees among young people, employers struggle to find job-ready talent. A recent national employability report revealed that only 42.6% of Indian graduates are actually employable, declining from 44.3% two years prior (Business Standard, 2024). More than half of college graduates do not meet the skill requirements of available jobs. The report pinpoints a widening gap between what universities produce and what industries need, especially as automation and AI reshape work.

Why are our graduates struggling? As Sameer Joshi, author and a consultant, observes: "We reward kids for regurgitating textbook answers, then wonder why they struggle with creative thinking later on." The academic path rewards absorbing vast content and scoring in standardized tests, rather than learning how to learn or applying knowledge creatively.

Curriculum overload: adding without subtracting

For decades, our education system simply piled on more material

without cutting down the outdated parts. Educational institutions rarely remove topics for fear of leaving something out; instead, they stretch the plate wider.

In 2018, the then Union HRD Minister admitted that the school syllabus had become more exhaustive than some college courses, calling it "cramped" and in urgent need of reduction (Indian Express, 2018). "From the academic session 2019, the NCERT syllabus will be reduced to half," he announced. Yet meaningful reduction has been slow and sporadic.

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 explicitly recognized the problem, recommending that curriculum content be reduced to core essentials to make space for critical thinking and inquiry-based learning (PIB, 2020). The policy says: Teach less, but teach it better. Focus on "key concepts, ideas, applications and problem-solving" rather than trying to cover everything.

However, turning that into reality is challenging. States often treat curricula as political battlegrounds. Consider the recent debate over the "three-language formula." The NEP proposed that children learn three languages to foster multilingual skills, but states like Tamil Nadu resisted, arguing that imposing a third language would burden students. Every additional compulsory subject crowds out time that could be spent mastering the basics or exploring personal interests.

Milind Nagda, educator and entrepreneur, captures this perfectly. He points out that while much needs to change in education, from how assessments are designed to how classrooms engage students, one of the most critical shifts is integrating design thinking and life-skills into the curriculum. For him, these are essential ingredients of an education system truly equipped for the 21st century. This overload has tangible consequences. Children today face cognitive loads that older generations can barely imagine. Their attention is pulled in so many directions that deep learning becomes difficult. Moreover, the relevance of the much mandated content is questionable. A few years from now, most facts they memorized will be irrelevant or easily looked up by AI, while skills they desperately need (critical thinking, managing people, etc.) might fall through the cracks.

The exam obsession: more pain, little gain

Nowhere is the "more is more" mentality as evident as in our approach to standardized exams. Indian education has this obsession for high-stakes examinations. Entire coaching industries thrive on the premise that students must ace these milestones at all costs. Parents double down on exam prep, schools teach to the test, and students internalize that their worth is tied to percentages and ranks.

Recent trends underscore how distorted this has become. In 2025, over two lakh CBSE students scored above 90% across classes 10 and 12. When one in ten or more examinees is getting 90% plus, it suggests either an incredible leap in learning or grade inflation. Education experts fear it's the latter. Chandrika Shenoy, an independent educator, emphasizes a deeper problem: "....board exams are still glorified. As long as the emphasis on exam performance persists, innovative approaches will struggle to take root, and the traditional pattern of education will continue unabated." We need a massive mindset shift. The purpose of schooling should be to make kids lifelong learners – adaptable, curious, resilient. Right now, exams do the opposite.

The human cost is severe. India's National Crime Records Bureau found that 7.6% of all suicides in 2022 were committed by students, with exam failure cited as a key factor. All of this is clearly indicative of the failure of our obsession to get children to do more!

Voices from educators

Educators across the ecosystem point to the need for "less is more" to achieve deeper learning and student wellbeing. For that to happen, the system also needs to really reimagine what millions of our over-burdened teachers are doing today. Koushik Prabhakaran, a CSR leader, emphasizes reducing non-value-adding workload on teachers: "They are bogged down with election work, data reports, endless paperwork. Freeing up teachers' time is crucial so they can focus on improving their teaching."

Arya Mishra, a teacher trainer, advocates for small but transformative changes. She has seen how simply changing classroom seating from rigid rows to group clusters transforms energy and engagement. "The traditional, militaristic way of seating is limiting interaction," she notes.

Sandeep Kannikanti, founder of a private education company, wants to shift focus from curriculum and exams to children's curiosity: "....the future is uncertain, so why are we drilling kids on content that might be irrelevant? Let children's questions lead the way, not just textbooks. I wish every child woke up eager to go to school."

Arya V, a non-profit leader, reflects on her own experience: "Growing up, I never associated joy with learning – it was always exam-focused. In our program, we make classrooms more engaging through peer teaching. It's amazing how performance improves when kids are actually enjoying the process."

These voices speak to different facets of reform, but there is a

common thread between all these voices. They all are advocating for less rigidity, less pressure, less top-down mandates. In their place, creativity, future-ready skills, joy, student agency is what is key. You can't have a playful, curiosity-driven classroom and simultaneously have kids preparing for 10 different exams.

Quality over quantity: the three Rs

So what fills the space when we begin to lighten the load? The answer, many educators agree, lies not in adding new material, but in shifting focus to what Kiran Bir Sethi, founder of Riverside School, calls the 3 Rs: Rigor, Relevance, and Relationships. It's a simple yet powerful framework that speaks not just to *what* we teach, but *how* we create meaningful learning.

Relevance is about helping students see real-world value in what they learn. Much of today's curriculum feels abstract or disconnected. But when lessons draw from students' lives through local issues, hands-on work, or personal projects, engagement deepens. Rigor is not about adding more things to the plate but about going deeper. A focused syllabus often demands more thinking than a broad one. Let students build, question, and apply. And at the core of it all is relationships. Learning thrives when teachers know their students, when peers work together, and when schools are connected to their communities. But this kind of teaching needs space and time, both of which are lost in an overloaded system.

The way forward

Shifting to "less is more" requires action at multiple levels. At the policy level, governments need to periodically reimagine what children learn and boldly trim outdated content. Individual schools don't have to wait for systemic change. They can innovate with smaller shifts, as simple as a tweak in the timetable. Countries that consistently top education benchmarks, like Finland, often have shorter school days, less homework, and leaner curricula, yet achieve superior outcomes (Finland Toolbox, 2021). Finnish students spend less time in class than most of their peers, and the system emphasizes learning how to learn over how much to learn.

The notion that "less is more" in education is not a utopian idea. It is one of the most critical shifts that needs to happen in the education system today. Doing less structurally can create space for doing more substantively.

If we continue piling more on an already overloaded system, we risk breaking the spirit of learners and educators alike. But if we have the courage to lighten the load, we might ignite a love of learning that enables this generation to heights we haven't imagined.

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TP

Experiential learning through MaaDoo

Four practical shifts every school can make

Team MaaDoo comprises

Mamatha R, Masters in commerce with a BEd, Mamatha is passionate about Nature and education. She has conducted nature awareness camps for government school children over the years and has been with Project MaaDoo since its inception.

Jaikumar R, a mechanical engineer with a keen passion for design, innovation, and nature, Jaikumar has also worked for many years to transform rural education. He has been with Project MaaDoo since its inception.

Nagesh OS, has a Masters in mathematics. He started out teaching engineering students, but his passion for Nature, education and serving rural communities brought him to MaaDoo. He now organizes nature awareness camps.

Nenike Hussain Basha Saab, has a Masters in physics. He is passionate about Kannada language and Nature. He has been working with Project MaaDoo for a few years now.

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If we could change schooling, we would replace "listen-and-recall" routines with experiences that let children *do, ask, connect,* and *care*. Many classrooms still divide subjects into silos, discourage questions, and judge success only by written tests. Project *MaaDoo** (Kannada: "I do") has shown in rural Bengaluru that four small redesigns; each feasible with existing resources, can turn any school into a laboratory of curiosity and community action. The activities below illustrate how learning-by-doing, inquiry, interdisciplinarity, and community engagement can coexist within a regular timetable, while quietly weaving in ethical values that exams seldom capture.

Activity 1: *Inquiry box* – normalizing student questions

Questioning is a powerful process in education. When students are encouraged to ask questions, they are required to think critically, which naturally fuels their curiosity and love for learning. Encouraging curiosity is the first step towards deeper understanding and meaningful learning.

Objective: Shift discussion from teacher-led recall to student-generated investigation, reinforcing research skills and confidence.

* An initiative of Ramakrishna Mission Shivanahalli supported by Youth for Seva and Texas Instruments

Photos courtesy: MaaDoo

Steps
Mount a sealed "Question Box" in every classroom. Any language and any handwriting are welcome.

Example questions students have asked:
- Why can we see our image in a mirror but not on a wall?
- Do all objects reflect light?
- Why don't we see a rainbow every time it rains?
- Why do plants take in oxygen at night?

These questions served as entry points into deeper inquiry with discussions varying from class to class. We kept the questions dynamic, building from one to another based on student responses, ensuring that everyone in the class was actively involved in the learning process. We also actively encourage students to ask questions related to the topic during and after the class.

Activity 2: *Interdisciplinary lens* – "inside an anthill"
When children first begin their schooling journey, they perceive the world as whole. They do not separate knowledge into compartments like science, math, or language. However, as educators, we often impose these artificial boundaries between subjects, leading students to see learning in fragments rather than as an interconnected experience. This fragmented approach can limit a child's ability to fully grasp and engage with the world around them.

Objective: Demonstrate how one natural structure embodies mathematics, physics, chemistry, and social science.

Steps
1. Field sketch: Learners trace the termite mound dimensions, estimating volume with the formula for a frustum.
2. Thermal probe: A kitchen thermometer records temperature at three different stages inside the mound; the data collected is taken back to class.
3. Chemical test: Collect a soil pinch to test the pH; link acidity to termites' calcium-rich saliva.
4. Society simulation: Groups role play worker, soldier, and queen castes akin to the termite world to debate labour distribution.

In **MaaDoo** schools, test scores in biology and math improved together because pupils no longer saw formulas and food chains as unrelated. Observing termite cooperation prompts reflection on human social contacts.

Activity 3: *Classroom to community* – "rainfall in your backyard"
As facilitators, we often assume that we have taught everything necessary just because we've "covered" the textbook – which we treat as the ultimate teaching source. But in reality, learning has no boundaries. Traditional classroom teaching using blackboards helps to some extent, but it doesn't completely fulfil the purpose of meaningful education. One powerful way to extend learning beyond the four walls of a classroom is by involving the community.

Objective: Connect meteorology to local farming decisions through real time data collection.

Steps

1. DIY rain gauge: Using a half cut plastic bottle, students mark millimetre scales and calibrate with kitchen measures.
2. Citizen science link: They call Varuna-Mithra, Karnataka's rainfall hotline, to log the official village rainfall.
3. Panchayat visit: Teams photograph the Atal Bhujal Yojana gauge, and interview officials and parents on water management.
4. Data briefs: Weekly charts compare school readings with hotline data; anomalies trigger discussion on micro-climates.

Learners realize that "millimetres" on TV weather are actionable numbers for crop planning. Confidence grows when parents consult their children before sowing.

Activity 4: *In-value-able: weaving values into everyday learning*

Education is incomplete if it touches only the mind. Project *MaaDoo* therefore treats values not as an extra period but as the invisible thread that ties every activity to life. Activities are designed such that values are embedded within the experience, encouraging students to see the ethical and emotional dimensions of their learning. Each activity in the *Maadoo* project contains a *core value* and we design experiences that help students *feel* it:

Activity	Value focus	How the value is lived
Eco-friendly Ganapati	Social responsibility	Learners craft clay or leaf-pulp idols, replace plastic décor with recycled paper, and host community games that reward waste-free practices. Because the festivities are public, children confront real choices: Will the community use disposable cups or wash steel ones? The children will see immediate social feedback.
Surface area of a leaf	Respect for all life forms	Measuring the lamina area with graph paper seems routine until discussion turns to how each square millimetre supports photosynthesis. Many students, unprompted, decide to pluck only fallen leaves for future sessions, and later persuade siblings to stop tearing foliage for play.

Conclusions

Pramod, one of our class 9 students from Bannimukkodlu village on the fringes of the Bannerghatta National Park decided to take action after a classroom activity called 'A day without plastic'. The activity explores the origin of plastic and its positive and negative impacts on living organisms, including humans. Moved by what he had learned, he gathered a group of his juniors and began collecting plastic trash from the edges of the forest near his village. The collected plastic was sent for recycling. Pramod's initiative shows how experiential learning can inspire students to act beyond the classroom. When classroom knowledge/education connects directly with the real world, students not only learn – they lead.

The four shifts we outlined above are simple: a box, an anthill visit, a rain bottle, and an invaluable value. Yet, together they reinvent schooling experience. Knowledge moves from the blackboard to the village path; assessment moves from "write what I said" to "show me what you explored"; values move from the moral science period to lived practice. Recent research on inquiry and interdisciplinary learning underscores their efficacy, but Pramod's cleanup or a farmer's new sowing date are the metrics that matter most. This Teacher's Day, we invite colleagues to try just one of the above before the end of term. Share your data sheets, sketches, and reflections in the staff room; let students present their findings in the assembly. The resulting buzz will be your proof that classrooms are too small for learning, and that children, when trusted, will exceed every curriculum standard we set.

Changing education does not always demand a lot of money or policy change. It begins when a teacher says, "Let's find out," steps outside, and watches curiosity light up a child's face. What first step will you take?

TP

The classroom as story

What changes when we tell and listen

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"Your story of that little girl who faced her fears and finally overcame it changed my life and had a deep impact on me. I started loving storytelling and theatre because of you. Thanks again for making me a confident person that I never saw."

This message, sent by a teacher after a storytelling session, made me sit up. Not because it praised my work – but because it reminded me what changes when a teacher begins to tell stories. This teacher lived every story she took to her classroom.

I've seen this shift countless times. A teacher stands up to tell a story, often with hesitation. *"I'm not a performer,"* she might say, or *"I'm not good with voices."* But slowly, as she steps into the world of the story, something changes. She's not just delivering content anymore. She is alive in the telling. And so are her students.

Storytelling does something no worksheet or whiteboard can. It humanizes. It draws people in. It invites vulnerability and expression. And for the teacher, it awakens a sense of voice – not just the literal voice, but the inner one that says, *I have something worth sharing.*

The storyteller inside the teacher

When a teacher begins to tell stories in the classroom, a transformation begins. This is not a performance skill. It is a pedagogical shift. I want to make a distinction here between telling and performing. Bringing a story to share with students to draw them into the lesson is not the same as acting it out. Storytelling in the classroom is about presence, intention, and connection – not theatrics. In telling stories, teachers who once focused on covering the syllabus begin to think in terms of narrative – sequence, suspense, metaphor, character. Their own understanding of the subject deepens. They move from explaining to evoking. From stating to connecting.

This change is often quiet but profound. I've seen teachers discover a joy they hadn't felt in years. *"I didn't know I could hold a room like that,"* one teacher said after her first storytelling session. Another told me, *"My students actually listened without me asking them to."*

And that's the magic of story. It invites attention, does not demand it. But it also invites something else that we rarely acknowledge in teacher training: play, emotion, and imagination. These are not distractions from learning. They are the foundation on which deep learning is built.

Listening is learning

But storytelling is only half the story. The other half – and just as important – is listening.

True listening is a learned skill. It requires focus, patience, and empathy. And in a world filled with distraction, teaching children to listen is one of the most radical acts a school can take on.

I've seen this impact echoed in the voices of students too. One student who was part of the school storytelling club told me: *"It paved the way for me to explore not just different nuances of performing in front of an audience, but also made me a more informed consumer of the various kinds of literature. I was able to articulate my thoughts with more ease and got a better grip on the writings in my English textbook. It helped me dissect a piece of writing and internalize it better than I could before."*

Storytelling didn't just build his confidence as an orator – it deepened his understanding, expression, and connection to literature.

In story-based classrooms, children don't just sit and absorb. They visualize, predict, recall, retell, and reflect. They become participants in meaning-making. A child who listens well begins to connect dots, imagine alternatives, and relate emotionally to concepts, whether it's a character in a folktale or a scientist making a discovery.

Which is why, I believe it's time we go beyond using storytelling as a one-off tool, and embed it into the curriculum itself.

A story-based curriculum – moving from performance to process

We often say *"learning should be joyful"* but do we plan for joy? If we truly believe joy matters, it must reflect in how we design learning experiences. And storytelling gives us the tools to do that.

Illustration: Shilpy Lather

This is why I believe we must build a story-based curriculum, at least up to grade 8, where storytelling and listening are not side activities or co-curricular boxes to tick, but core pedagogical practices.

Too often, storytelling enters the school space only in the form of competitions. The goal becomes a medal or applause. While these events may build confidence, they also risk framing storytelling as a performance for others, rather than a process for oneself.

Story*telling* is a way of knowing. A way of teaching. A way of learning. When a child retells a concept in their own words, they take ownership of it. When a teacher tells a story about a historical event, a scientific discovery, or even a math problem, they invite curiosity and connection.

A story-based curriculum might look like this:

- History is taught through diaries, letters, and dramatized events that allow multiple viewpoints.
- Science concepts are introduced through narrative dilemmas: Why did this happen? What did she discover? What was the turning point?
- Maths becomes a series of puzzles, riddles, or real-life scenarios told through stories.
- Legal studies explores laws through landmark cases told as courtroom stories, debates around rights and justice presented through dramatized hearings, or fictional narratives that raise ethical questions around legality.
- Listening circles are part of every week – where teachers and children listen to and reflect on each other's stories without judgment.
- Assessment includes oral narration, illustrated retellings, or imaginative applications of a concept, alongside written tests.

This is not about replacing the syllabus or doing away with the textbook (although, that might be ideal!) – it's about reframing it through story, so that both teacher and student engage with it more meaningfully.

What changes in the school?

When storytelling and listening are valued as core practices, the school culture itself changes. Classrooms become spaces of trust and imagination, not just instruction. Children who may struggle with textbook formats often thrive when they are invited to express what they've understood in story form. Teachers begin to collaborate across subjects, weaving shared narratives that cross disciplinary boundaries.

Most importantly, relationships deepen. Children start to listen to each other more. Teachers begin to notice nuances in how students respond. There is more joy. More connection. And a shared sense of *we are learning together*.

Is this scalable?

I believe it is because it doesn't require expensive infrastructure or radical policy overhaul. It requires a shift in mindset. It asks us to value the imaginative and the emotional as much as we value the cognitive.

Many curricular frameworks already call for holistic, interdisciplinary, and creative approaches. Story is a natural vehicle for all of these. What we need now is teacher support and space – time to plan, co-create, and reflect on storytelling practices. We need training that focuses not just on voice modulation, but on how to find the story in every lesson.

The teacher as a listener too

The most beautiful stories I've heard from teachers are not just about what they told students – but about what they heard in return. A child retelling a folktale in their home language. A student drawing a comic strip of a science story. A quiet child who finally spoke up because the story made them feel seen.

And sometimes, a message like this: *"Your story changed my life. I started loving storytelling and theatre because of you."*

When teachers begin to tell stories, they change. When children begin to listen and tell stories, learning becomes a shared act of imagination. When schools honour both, education becomes what it was always meant to be: a deeply human journey.

What if the most radical change we could make to education is also the oldest? What if we told more stories – and listened better?

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Connecting books to backyards

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In real life, subjects do not exist in silos. A walk through any neighborhood proves this: you see how geography shapes a city's biodiversity, how social structures affect waste management, how science explains why trees grow a certain way, or why a drain overflows during monsoon. But step inside a classroom, and these living connections are replaced with separate textbooks, separate periods, and separate exams.

If I could change education, I would begin by weaving subjects back together – right where students live and learn every day.

We know that systemic change takes time. The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 itself talks about breaking silos and integrating learning. But this vision cannot come alive through policy alone – it needs living examples that show how it works, even inside everyday schools.

At Thicket Tales, this is what we build through our flagship program, Learn Around Nature (LAN) – a year-long, experiential learning journey for middle school students, especially from low-income families. It weaves science, geography, and social science together through outdoor classrooms, experiments, discussions, and real projects.

Place-based education: breaking silos in three proven ways
Place-based education connects concepts and surroundings – and here are three ways we see this every day through LAN:

Photos courtesy: Thicket Tales

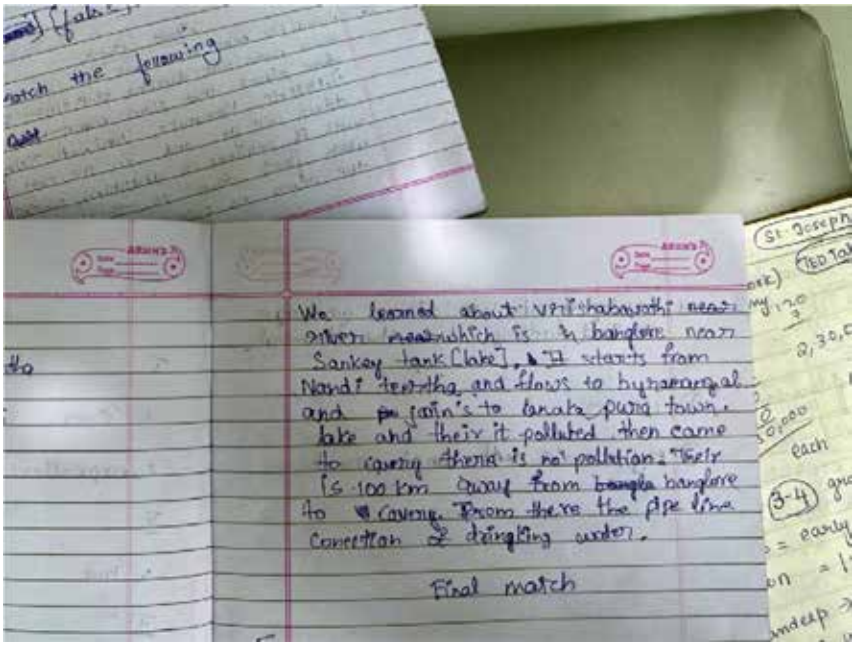
1. Relevance – Students find their spark
When learning is rooted in real life, students care.

Today, many children lose interest in studies because they don't see the point. They learn about biodiversity but rarely step into a park to spot a single bird. They memorize facts about water systems but don't walk to the neighborhood drain to ask why it floods every monsoon.

LAN flips this. Textbooks become field guides. Schools become launch pads for outdoor classrooms.

Last year, 240 students explored how Bengaluru's biodiversity and city design shape each other. Children, who once thought Nature was far away, discovered it right under their feet – in the cracks of sidewalks and tiny parks squeezed between buildings.

One 8th grader told us:
"Watching Nature is super cool! It helps us notice everything around us and makes us feel calm and happy."



When learning connects to daily life, students don't just remember facts – they begin to ask:
Who lives here? What does this tell me about my city? What can I do about it?

2. Application – Textbook concepts come alive
Place-based education makes ideas visible and usable.

School books often cover landscapes, rivers, water bodies, scarcity – but these stay abstract unless children see them where they live.

In LAN, students did not just read about rivers – they traced the rivers of Bengaluru on an interactive map made by Paani, a local water initiative. They mapped networks of rivers and lakes that sustain their city – many of which they had crossed daily without noticing.

In that moment, "water scarcity" was no longer a line in a chapter – it became the story of their own city. Drains, rivers, and floods became real.

When students apply textbook ideas in hyper local contexts, they gain knowledge they can use. These backyard connections help children truly see their surroundings – the first spark of change-making. They start to ask:
"What can I do about this?"

3. 21st century skills – from knowing to doing
When students tackle local problems, they grow practical skills for life.

Learning becomes action when students pick a problem from their own backyard. LAN students work on issues like waste management, increasing green spaces, and improving mobility. They research, test solutions, talk to communities, and present their ideas at public showcases.

This builds skills we call "21st century" but are really timeless: curiosity, observation, critical thinking, teamwork, clear communication. Our assessments show real growth – students improved collaboration and

communication from 30% to over 60% in just one year. Over 90% of visitors at our showcase rated student presentations as clear, confident, and creative.

When learning feels real, children naturally grow into the citizens we hope they will become: thoughtful observers, effective team players, and efficient problem-solvers.

All of this connects back to climate education

Too often, climate education stops at awareness. We tell children the planet is in crisis but don't show them how to act. LAN bridges this gap by giving students safe, guided spaces to test solutions that matter – starting with their own neighborhoods.

Through these simple, local acts – tracing rivers, mapping waste, designing greener spaces – children practice what it means to be *climate citizens*. They see how daily life and Nature are intertwined. They see that change starts here.

Bringing schools, teachers, and families along

This change is possible only when schools, teachers, and families believe in the power of learning outdoors.

We know it's not always easy. Teachers need training, schools need trust, and parents need to see that an outdoor classroom is not a picnic – it's where deep, meaningful learning happens.

That's why we work closely with educators through training and design support. We help schools see that NEP's dream of experiential, integrated learning is not a distant future – it can happen *now*, one backyard at a time.

A call to every educator

If I could change education, I would start by asking every teacher:

What story does your neighborhood tell?

What problem can your students help solve – right now, right here? The answers are waiting just outside the classroom door.

If we want students who care, who notice, who question, who act – we must give them chances to *do* these things for real.

At Thicket Tales, we are only one small example. But when we connect books to backyards, we don't just teach lessons – we raise active citizens, ready for the climate challenges and local issues of tomorrow.

Let's build this together

To see how our students do this, visit our showcase: https://heyzine.com/flip-book/0727fadea6.html

Education cannot change overnight. But every teacher can open a door, every lesson can become an exploration, and every child can discover that learning is not a burden – it is a way to shape their world.

This Teacher's Day, ask your students:

"What's the first problem you'd like to solve in your backyard?"

The answers may surprise you. They may inspire you. And they may just show us the future we need.

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Compassion not competition at the heart of the education system

Vikash Sharma and **Ananya Pathak** are founders of Shiksha Swaraj Creative Learning and Resource Centre, Patna, Bihar. They can be reached at vikashsharma946@gmail.com.

The opportunity to write and reflect on what needs to change within the education system is both fascinating and challenging. It is challenging because to arrive at an answer, we have to inspect the suggestions, feedback, and ideas we received from hundreds of first-generation learners who enter the education system with a dream not only for themselves but often for their families and even communities, which have been deprived and humiliated for generations. Their individual education trajectories are seldom smooth, as such children do not come from an environment that nurtures learning, fosters creativity or cultivates their individual potential or uniqueness. As people working with such children, we understand the complex and multilayered issues within the education system from the perspective of the most downtrodden and disadvantaged groups.

The world of a first-generation learner

As first-generation learners from poor, economically disadvantaged, and socially marginalized communities, children come to the learning environment hungry, sleepy, exhausted (often due to extensive domestic/agricultural work to help their parents), and emotionally wounded. The challenge for the educator is therefore not only to deliver a lesson, help children decipher new ideas and concepts in a chapter, or formulate answers to the questions at the back of the lesson, but also to step into the child's inner world, which is fragmented, broken, and wounded. As the founders of

Photos courtesy: Shiksha Swaraj Creative Learning and Resource Centre

Educationist Prof. Avijit Pathak with young learners at Shiksha Swaraj Creative Learning and Resource Centre.

Shiksha Swaraj Creative Learning and Resource Centre, we have had the opportunity to work with children whose voices are seldom heard by the mainstream, but which are full of aspirations and desire to excel in their educational journeys despite the adverse conditions of life.

Any attempt to discuss the changes/transformations that the education system requires would be incomplete without listening to such voices. In the paragraphs that follow we will try to highlight some of the several aspects that are in desperate need of a metamorphosis within the learning machinery. These points have resulted from innumerable open-hearted discussions that we have been initiating at our centre. These discussions encouraged open dialogue, extensive questioning, and critical thinking about educational problems that these children experience on an everyday basis ranging from lack of basic school infrastructure, scarcity of teachers, and textbooks that do not speak to them to an often torturous examination system that has rote learning built into its very core.

Empathy and compassion: the key to a holistic education

For many children, the education system is no less than an alienating, gigantic, impersonal machinery that is oppressive with its emphasis on cut-throat competition, examinations that deepen hierarchy, textbooks that fail to capture one's imagination, classroom interactions that are mechanical or lack the touch of empathy, etc. With a heavy backpack and droopy shoulders, many children dread school. Dalit children are often compelled to sit in specially demarcated spaces, drink only from designated taps within the school premises, and are mocked and ridiculed because of their caste. Female students assist with domestic chores like cooking, cleaning, attending to younger siblings at home before they attend school even as they constantly deal with the pressure of marriage as they approach adolescent years. Within many families in rural India, from an early age, young girls are oriented for marriage, and learning of household chores and nurturing tasks are given more importance than academic or other creative pursuits. Planning for a career is seldom a choice. Low family income, lack of exposure to the world outside accompanied by orthodox/conventional perceptions of gender, heavily limit the opportunities for most female students who struggle to even graduate from high school.

Working in rural Bihar has enabled us to see how the intersectionality of caste and class shapes access to education and opportunity for first-generation learners. The school, therefore, needs to undergo an urgent transformation and become a more holistic and liberating space, which not only imparts the curriculum and gives an officially recognized degree but also becomes a catalyst for social change. At the heart of such a transformation will be the need to work on an empathic and compassionate education that touches the inner world of the learners and aids in the birth of resilient communities that acknowledge shared issues and fight them collectively. For the school to become the center of social change, we need educators who have chosen to be in the vocation and are full of love and empathy.

School and the community

When we work with children from such challenging backgrounds we realize that our work as teachers is not just to teach mathematics or English, but also to understand where the learner is coming from – has she eaten at least one filling meal in the last few days, is the bleeding wound on his forehead a result of a domestic scuffle with his drunkard father, what is life like for the bright young Dalit girl who wants to become a doctor when she grows up, but her mother wants to marry her off the next month?

Our teachers, classrooms, textbooks, and examinations have failed to understand the world of these learners or make sense of their realities, and therefore they appear remote, unrelatable, and alienating. The illustrations in the textbooks are urban, the language is full of terminologies they have seldom heard, and most parts of the syllabus are beyond their understanding. With the fear of examinations hovering over them, most first-generation learners depend on poor quality guide books and guess papers, which they rote learn to sparingly pass their exams. Step into a rural government school in a state like Bihar and you will know how callous the system is. Yes, the leaking roofs of the classrooms after the torrential rains, blocked and overflowing drains inside school washrooms, absence of clean drinking water, contaminated school lunches, corporal punishments, cases of physical and mental abuse against children from the oppressed castes are only a few amid the innumerable challenges that children face on an everyday basis. Why would a child of an impressionable age want to attend school in these circumstances?

Other everyday pertinent challenges include the inability to understand the language of instruction, as in many rural areas students speak a different language making it difficult for them to understand the material or participate in classroom discussion effectively, unwillingness to spend on education especially in the case of the girl child, inadequate deployment of teachers or the appointment of only contractual teachers, complete lack of digital infrastructure and therefore a complete loss of touch with the rest of the world. Along with systemic alterations, there is a need to promote digital literacy

A glimpse from our monthly 'Reading Day Program' where a large number of children and youth from neighbouring villages participate in engaging activities.

so that the digital divide too can be bridged and children in rural areas are no longer isolated from their urban peers. It is ironic how in a globalized economy which boasts of enhanced digitalization, most schools in rural India have never even touched a computer, accessed the internet, or watched a film online. Computer laboratories do exist, but only in policy documents. No wonder, the wide and vast world that is connected and growing is far from the reaches of these children, keeping them literally confined to a dark box.

The school is therefore endowed with an immense responsibility to be the leading institution within the community. The school must be visualized not only as an institution like several others within the community but as the most important agent of social transformation. Whether it is communal violence, caste injustice, gender discrimination or any other social malice, the school must remain a sacred and sacrosanct institution where injustice is met with justice and all forms of violence are banished by unconditional love and empathy. This can happen if schools encourage members of the community including children, parents, and guardians along with other interested people to have an important say in the management of the school. This will help towards the much-needed decentralization of decision-making, incorporation of on-ground concerns and generation of authentic feedback for the future development and betterment of the school system.

Other ideas towards the goal could include having regular community meetings and feedback sessions where all members of the community openly talk about educational challenges and possible solutions, contribute to its resources by donating funds, food grains, wood for making school furniture, or even their physical labor towards its maintenance from time to time. Such involvement may help build a strong sense of accountability and responsibility towards the school as a shared and important social institution. If the community participates in the sustenance and development of the school, the demand for quality schooling will also grow. All these efforts will certainly leave a positive impact on the functionality of schools and help to drastically transform people's orientation towards education, especially in rural communities. After all, who can deny the fact that when the community at large is invited to become part of the school and people begin to see the light it can bring into their children's lives, they will begin to give importance to education and thereby help to nurture the primary institution that imparts it.

It is important for us to acknowledge that there are innumerable challenges within the education system and it is impossible to highlight them all within the limited scope of an article. All we have tried to do in the above paragraphs is to share with you the realities inflicting the rural school system, especially for first-generation learners.

There is a need to address these issues and work on initiatives that will help transform the educational landscape, but this will require a strong administrative commitment, extensive community engagement, and the support of all the relevant stakeholders, without which it will all appear like a distant dream.

It is high time we all came together to make learning a pleasant and life-transforming journey for all children. Let this system not just remain limited to a degree providing machine but become a catalyst, a leader of social change. Let us unleash the powers of education as it frees us from the limitations of caste, class, colour, gender and all other limiting identities merging us all in the limitless oceans of a shared, common humanity.

(The article refers to Shiksha Swaraj Creative Learning and Resource Centre, Madhopur village, Patna. It is a pioneering creative learning and resource Centre started in 2021 dedicated to empowering rural children and youth through experiential, community-rooted education. Based in Bihar, it fosters critical thinking, self-resilience and local wisdom by combining academic learning with hands-on projects, cultural knowledge and sustainable living.)

TP

Building an equitable society

Starting with our classrooms

Dr. Indumathi Sundararaman, is an educational consultant and researcher who has worked with various NGOs, including Quest Alliance and Breakthrough. She has developed and taught in various teacher education programs in universities such as TISS and APU. Her work and research interests span across gender and education, STEM education, and teacher professional development. She is based in Bengaluru and can be reached at mailindusow@gmail.com.

To build a truly inclusive and equitable society, we must begin with our schools. I envision an education system where no student – regardless of gender – is left behind, where every child can access and participate in quality learning experiences. My work, designing a gender and STEM curriculum, training educators, conducting parental workshops, and researching gender in education across government schools in multiple states, has indicated that systemic change is possible – if we approach it with intention and persistence.

This article is divided into two parts. The first, shares my experiences of implementing gender education in schools and its impact. The second discusses the challenges we face and the systemic shifts needed to make gender equity a reality in education.

What research tells us

My findings (Sundararaman, 2020), along with other studies (Chanana, 2007; Bhog, Bharadwaj & Mullick, 2012; Indumathi, 2014; Manjrekar, 2020), highlight deep-rooted issues in our school systems:

- School environments often mirror and reinforce existing gender norms.
- Teachers may unconsciously bring biases into the classroom.
- Textbooks still contain gendered language and lack diverse role models.
- Students engage in peer discrimination, often using sexist language.
- Parental influence reinforces gender stereotypes at home.

These patterns result in far-reaching consequences. Girls, in particular, are less likely to pursue higher education, and the gender gap only widens in fields like science, technology, and leadership. This gap does not begin in universities or workplaces – it starts much earlier, in schools. Over time, these early biases culminate in the under-representation of women in science, technology, entrepreneurship, and decision-making roles across sectors. This is not just an issue of access, but also of aspiration. Girls may internalize these biases, believing they are less suited for certain careers. Boys, too, grow up within limiting scripts of masculinity, unable to express vulnerability or choose non-traditional paths. Schools have the power to break this cycle – if equipped with the right tools and mindsets.

Policy support for gender equity

India's education policy frameworks recognize these disparities. **NCF 2005** emphasizes the importance of schools and classrooms being inclusive. **NEP 2020** furthers this vision by advocating for gender equity, empowering female teachers, and establishing a gender inclusion fund to support girls and transgender students.

Integrating gender education into the school curriculum leads to meaningful outcomes:

- Challenges and dismantles stereotypes.
- Encourages inclusive and safe learning spaces.
- Promotes critical thinking about power and hierarchy.
- Fosters student agency in education and career decisions.
- Enhances learning outcomes by ensuring equal access.
- Shapes respectful and equitable relationships.
- Reinforces positive social norms.

A ground-level view: gender and STEM education

Partnering with Quest Alliance, I had the opportunity to design a **STEM for Girls** curriculum and work with teachers, head teachers, and parents. We aimed to bridge the gender gap in STEM fields and empower girls to make informed career choices.

The curriculum addressed gender and sex, gender norms, stereotypes, rights, exploration of self, careers, and showcased inspiring women scientists, all through an intersectional lens.

At first, progress was slow. Many teachers were uncomfortable using words like "sex" in classrooms and hesitated to explore these themes. But through sustained training, things began to shift. We started sharing our personal experiences, which helped teachers open up; they began to reflect on their lives, and gradually felt comfortable discussing these ideas with students.

During the workshop, a female teacher shared: "We both work, but when I go home, I fetch water and serve a glass/bottle of water to my husband."

This sparked a flood of personal stories. Another teacher added, "I work and earn, but my debit card and PIN are with my husband."

Some male teachers questioned paid maternity leave or commented on their female colleagues' attire. But with time, many began to reflect on their roles more critically.

One male teacher proudly shared, "I cook in the morning, pack the boxes for my children and wife, while my wife washes clothes or does other chores, and we leave home together at 8. I cannot call this help; this is my responsibility."

A female teacher talked about her sister starting a successful home business and now teaching others – men and women alike – about financial planning.

As the workshops progressed, defensiveness gave way to genuine engagement. Teachers began acknowledging the stereotypes shaping their lives and expressed a willingness to challenge them. These conversations humanized the issue.

Illustration: Shilpy Lather

Teachers no longer saw gender as an abstract topic, but something that affected their everyday lives, inside and outside the classroom. As teachers began transforming their thinking, the ripple effects extended to their students as well.

What changed in classrooms

In a recent impact study (Sundararaman, Thirumalai, and Nadaf, 2025), we observed promising signs of transformation:

In an Odisha school, a teacher described how a gender hackathon helped students recognize and challenge stereotypes. She noted:

> "Boys have understood that girls have interesting ideas to solve a problem."

In Karnataka, a teacher shared that she conducts group activities where boys and girls hold hands and participate equally in sweeping, decorating, and leadership tasks; in her words,

> "Sweeping works now boys are doing using long brooms… leadership tasks are also designated for both girls and boys, serving food, both boys and girls do together, even decoration in the school, Rangoli, flower decoration, they do them together." (p.26)

Teachers noticed that these conversations and activities extended beyond the classroom.

"The things we discuss in school reach home as well," said one teacher, adding "Some students can voice their views and opinions at home and assert themselves with their parents."

In parent workshops, some mothers, especially from urban areas, expressed commitment to supporting their daughters' education and delaying marriage so their daughters could pursue careers of their choice.

These testimonies show that gender education has an impact on students' lives.

Challenges and the road ahead

However, this kind of transformation does not happen overnight. It takes years, and is not without challenges.

Despite progress, some teachers continue to believe that gender bias does not exist in their schools. Many face difficulties implementing the curriculum, especially when trained teachers are transferred or leadership is unsupportive. There is also the issue of scale – how do we ensure continuity and expansion beyond the intervention classes? Sustainability remains a major concern for NGOs: *How do we institutionalize this work?*

Moreover, real systemic change also requires political will. Gender equity must become a priority at every level of governance and educational leadership. Without structural support and budgetary allocation, even the best-intentioned programs struggle to survive beyond the project cycle.

Institutionalizing gender education

Systemic support is critical. State governments and educational institutions must step in. The possible measures are

- **Curriculum reform:** NGOs like Breakthrough have worked with states like Odisha and Punjab to embed gender equity into the core curriculum – stories, role models, and activities are now part of English and social science textbooks.
- **Teacher education:** Gender training must be integrated into pre-service programs like D.Ed. and B.Ed. In-service programs can be offered as certified courses in collaboration with universities to provide deeper engagement.
- **Continuous support:** One-off workshops are not enough. Ongoing mentorship, peer learning networks, and institutional structures involving DIETs, SCERTs, and resource persons at district and block levels are essential.
- **School leadership involvement:** Head teachers must be active partners. Their support enables peer mentoring and whole-school change.
- **Community engagement:** Beyond schools, the government should launch campaigns to challenge gender norms and engage parents and communities in the conversation.

We must also leverage technology to build digital communities of practice, share resources, and foster collaboration among educators across regions.

Change is possible – but only when gender education is not treated as a one-time intervention. It must become a sustained, collective effort embedded in our systems, our schools, and our mindsets. When teachers, parents, policymakers, and students all take ownership of equity, the ripple effects can transform not just classrooms, but society itself. Gender education is not just an add-on – it is the foundation of a just, inclusive, and progressive society.

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Help every child shine

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As a teacher, I view education in schools as a dynamic journey of growth, not as a sprint to a test score. Classrooms should serve as launch pads where students begin exploring, driven by curiosity and supported by guidance. Lessons should be less about memorizing facts and more about igniting questions that deepen understanding and foster critical thinking.

Each student's path is distinct. A child puzzled by algebraic equations today might excel at creative writing tomorrow. Errors should not be seen as failures but as opportunities that foster perseverance and critical thinking. As educators, we must provide the tools that will encourage students to overcome obstacles.

School should extend beyond academics, cultivating skills like teamwork in group tasks, compassion in debates, and innovation in projects. These experiences will mould well-rounded, resilient individuals. While grades provide benchmarks, the true aim should be to prepare students for lifelong learning. By nurturing a passion for discovery, we must empower students to embrace their ongoing journey, ready to adapt and thrive in an ever-changing world.

As a teacher, I believe school is about helping kids discover what they're good at and love doing. Education isn't just about fixing weaknesses – it should be about finding and helping each child's strengths grow. Lea Waters, a renowned positive psychology expert and educator from Australia, says strengths have three parts: doing something well, feeling

Photos courtesy: The Peepal Grove School

excited about it, and doing it often. For example, a child who loves building with blocks, makes amazing models, and builds every chance they get, has a strength. We need to find what makes our children light up. To focus on students' strengths, we need to change how we think. I keep a journal to note down when my students' eyes light up, what gives them joy, what they gravitate towards. I see that some of my students are great at solving problems, like figuring out a tricky puzzle, others shine in art or music, creating beautiful work, some love reading about animals, while some others are happiest playing basketball. Traits like being curious or caring also stand out, shaping how children act and learn.

When children do something they love, they often get into a "flow" – they're so focused and happy that time just flies. This shows us that that particular activity or subject is an area of strength. For example, a student who spends hours drawing without getting bored is in a flow state.

Helping kids improve on their strengths happens in stages. First, we should spot the strength – something they're good at, love, and do often. Next, we must help them practice it, like letting them perform in a school play. This takes effort from both the student and the teacher. Finally, the strength becomes something they're good at, like starring in the play or winning a storytelling contest.

When we praise our students, we must be specific. Instead of saying, "I love how you made everyone laugh with your story," we should say, "Your story had such great timing and expression – it made

everyone laugh!" This helps students feel proud without feeling controlled.

Here are some simple steps to help children improve their strengths:

1. **Focus differently:** Notice when children do well or seem happy, not just when they struggle. Be aware of your own habit of focusing on the negative.
2. **Give chances to shine:** Let children try things they love, like joining a club or doing a project their way. A child who loves history might enjoy making a poster about it.
3. **Watch growth:** Check if a strength is turning into something bigger. Does a child who loves drawing, start creating amazing artwork? Keep track of their progress.
4. **Encourage flow:** Help children do activities where they lose track of time because they're so happy, like building, writing, or playing.
5. **Focus on strengths:** Talk about weaknesses, but spend more time celebrating what children do well to help them feel confident.

As teachers, we can transform our classrooms by focusing on students' strengths. Start by observing your students with fresh eyes – notice when they're excited or do something well, like leading a group or creating art. Write these moments in a journal to shift your focus from their weaknesses. Next, offer children opportunities to explore their passions, like joining a drama club or doing a science project. Watch how their strengths grow, from small skills to big achievements, and be specific in your praise, like saying, "Your painting shows amazing creativity!" This builds confidence without pressure. Encourage activities where children lose track of time, showing they're using their strengths. Reflect on your own biases – do you focus too much on low grades? By celebrating strengths, we help children feel proud and motivated.

If we don't, who will? Let's commit to nurturing every child's unique gifts, creating a classroom where they shine and grow into confident, capable people.

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Making space for compassion and clarity

Swati Gautam loves teaching children. Each child she teaches holds a special place in her heart. A poet, storyteller, and proud mother of a confident 26-year-old lawyer daughter, she values learning, empathy, gratitude, and self-awareness as essential elements of her teaching journey. She can be reached at swatigautam@gmail.com.

If I could change one thing in the education system, it would be to work towards nurturing empathetic individuals with a deep sense of gratitude. To achieve this, I would suggest that schools dedicate time for self-awareness and expression. I believe it is essential to ensure that every child is given the space to think and reflect. Looking at the world around us, it is clear that we need empathetic and sensitive individuals – those who can see beyond false media propaganda and view everyone as human beings, without any dividing lines.

To achieve this, we will need teachers who can think and reflect. Reflective writing practices or workshops should be made mandatory for teachers. When designing the B.Ed. curriculum or any teacher training course, it should include training that encourages critical thinking and reflection.

Circle time – (self-reflection and a safe space for expressing and sharing)
I feel that in the initial years of learning, children should be inculcated with the habit of gratitude, and that can only come through self-reflection and expression. Classrooms should include more circle time, and as teachers, we must create a safe space for listening. Listening with compassion and respect needs to be encouraged.

Schools should do away with memory-based, year-end summative assessments for younger children. Instead, assessments should be based on their everyday behaviour and interactions with those around them. They should be gently nudged to become more patient and empathetic.

I dream of classrooms where children are taught to reflect on their thoughts, on what they read, and on the world around them. I want children to be able to identify propaganda and not to blindly believe every piece of news they hear, but to fact-check, question, and reason. I want them to grow into thoughtful, independent individuals who can filter biases and see the world with clarity and compassion. Such individuals will undoubtedly develop a deep sense of empathy.

Space for discussion and dialogue
Children should have the space to express their views on various issues and events around the world. Teachers and students can together jot down ideas for mindful discussions where children are encouraged to raise their voices with respect and support their thoughts with facts. It is essential that they are heard patiently, and their views are received with dignity and openness.

When we speak of equality and social justice, we must begin early. Schools should be spaces that promote and nurture dialogue. Children

must be given opportunities to meet, interact with, and understand those who are marginalized. It is crucial that they don't grow up perceiving the poor or homeless as lazy or undeserving. These assumptions must be questioned, and children should be guided to explore the deeper causes of poverty and inequality.

I strive to bring relevance to every story, poem, or drama in my classroom. I encourage children to explore the underlying messages through discussion and inquiry, rather than spoon-feed them the answers. This approach allows their understanding to become personal and meaningful. Each child learns at their own pace and in their own way.

This practice fosters the ability to understand different points of view and helps children learn to respect differing opinions. Over time, it nurtures empathy and shapes them into compassionate human beings.

Practising gratitude

If every school in our country begins to nurture a mindset of gratitude, through small but meaningful classroom practices, our children will not only grow academically, but also into humane, aware, and grateful citizens.

This should become a conscious, national policy direction in education. Across all schools, rural or urban, government or private, we need to intentionally create space for practicing gratitude, empathy, and responsibility through everyday learning.

In my own school, especially in my Hindi classes, I have been trying to sow the seeds of this change. I encourage students to notice the people who support them every day – the support staff who cook, clean, maintain the gardens, and create a safe space. I want them to be self-aware and internally motivated, rather than simply respond to external

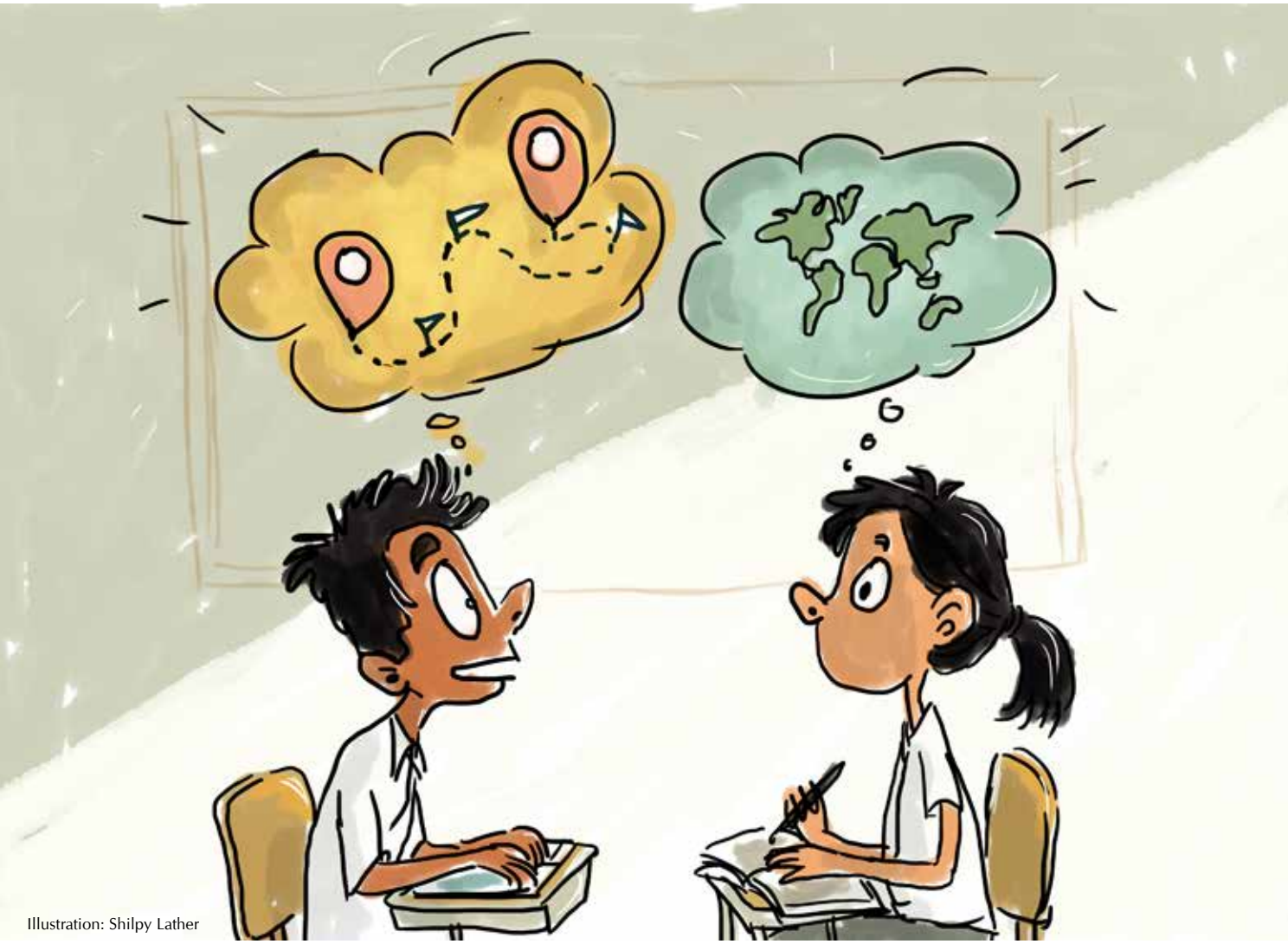

Illustration: Shilpy Lather

pressures. My goal is to nurture thoughtful individuals who act with fairness and sensitivity.

While we focus on the basics – reading, writing, and comprehension – we also spend time asking "why": Why are we learning this? Why is it important? How does it relate to the world around us? These questions ground learning in real-world relevance and spark empathy.

I think each school should try to bring the real world into the classroom and help children learn basic human characteristics like gratitude. If this becomes a national priority, our schools can become the beginning point for a more humane, just, and sensitive society.

Building empathy through storytelling

Stories are a powerful tool for communication. Children listen and see their own lives mirrored back. Without being told what to think, they draw their own meanings. This allows them to reflect, navigate their emotions, and build inner resilience. It also encourages critical thinking, often more effectively than direct instruction.

Personally, I avoid ending a story with a moral like, *"So the lesson is…"* because that narrows the child's imagination. Let them absorb the story and interpret it in their own way. When we push a conclusion, we risk turning the story into a lecture instead of an experience.

Stories are the most powerful medium I know for teaching difficult or sensitive concepts. Whether the goal is to explain, reflect, or simply hold a safe space for emotions – stories work. They provoke thought, stir feelings, and open dialogue. Most importantly, stories build bridges between people, experiences, and hearts.

As teachers, we must allow stories to help children's imaginations soar. In those skies of wonder, critical thinking and compassion take flight together. When a child listens deeply to a story – not just to listen, but to feel and understand – they become more human, more whole.

If I had the opportunity to make lasting changes to the education system, I would integrate all of the above as essential elements for cultivating gratitude and empathy in young minds. The world today urgently needs compassionate, sensitive individuals – and schools must not remain mere factories producing subject experts who lack emotional awareness or human connection.

Instead, schools should become spaces where essential human values are lived and practiced every day. If we truly want a world free of conflicts and boundaries, we must begin by nurturing emotional intelligence from a young age: encouraging critical thinking and questioning; enabling children to connect and empathize with people from all social backgrounds; grounding learning in real-world relevance; making language education a joyful, creative, and expressive experience; and fostering a deep concern for the environment.

Most importantly, we must remind ourselves that education is not just about what we know, but about who we become.

These changes, I believe, will raise a generation of conscious, kind, and courageous individuals – young people who won't merely adapt to society, but who will shape it with compassion and clarity.

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Through the green lens

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One of the most severe global crises is looming upon us – one that has already damaged the planet's resources irreparably and has brought us on the verge of the sixth mass extinction. Climate change is no longer a concept limited to theoretical discussions in scientific circles; it has quietly permeated and altered every aspect of our existence. In the first 90 days of 2025, there were 87 days when some or the other part of our country experienced extreme weather including floods, storms, heatwaves, or landslides. Even as some states reel under the impact of severe floods, average temperature continues to soar to record highs across the country, and even states like Meghalaya are experiencing a major rainfall deficit. In this unpredictable scenario, children are disproportionately vulnerable to the severe impacts of climate change. This vulnerability partly arises from the crucial impact of the environment on their physical, emotional, and mental development and often manifests as climate anxiety in children, as several studies* have suggested.

In these troubled times, our only ray of hope is learning from the mistakes of our ancestors and passing down this wisdom to our children. Nurturing a generation of conscious and committed citizens can potentially drive positive environmental action from the grassroot level. Hence, I believe that integrating environment education into all aspects of classroom

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Environment education class in progress.

Photos courtesy: Zila Parishad High School Gandaboyanapalli, Andhra Pradesh

discourse is one of the most important changes that needs to be brought about in Indian classrooms.

The idea that inculcating environmental consciousness should form an integral aspect of formal education is not a new one. In 1991, troubled by the alarming rate of pollution in the Ganga, M.C. Mehta filed a PIL in the Supreme Court of India. This led to a landmark decision by the apex court – all formal education institutions, from schools to universities, were mandated to include a component of environment education. NCF 2005 advocated for a paradigm shift in education with environment education at the heart of this shift and indigenous knowledge about sustainable resource consumption as one of the guiding values. School textbooks developed with this view incorporated different aspects of environmental degradation, and discussions around pollution, waste management, deforestation, etc., became a part of science classrooms. These discussions brought theoretical concepts around global warming and climate change to the classroom. Students were exposed to the idea that human activities have caused irreversible changes to the planet, and these may be far more severe than previously thought. However, these discussions remained confined to the classroom due to gaps in the implementation of NCF recommendations. While theoretical knowledge was being imparted to children, scope for the active construction of knowledge remained missing in a majority of the classrooms. True environment education is not concerned only with knowledge – it encompasses a shift in attitudes and values, as well as the acquisition of skills necessary for such a shift. Its ultimate aim is to empower students to understand how climate change is impacting them, and search for measures to mitigate and effectively adapt to this change.

Such environment education cannot come through theoretical discussions and poring over textbooks alone. A sound theoretical foundation is undoubtedly necessary to initiate meaningful conversations. However, this knowledge should enable children to see the world through the lens of environmental conservation, instead of being an isolated discussion in science or social science classrooms. It should help them question activities they engage in on a daily basis, and then think of better alternatives. They should be able to see linkages between global catastrophes and the day-to-day problems in their community. Environment education should not stop at learning; it should progress to "learning and doing".

A wonderful example of such an environment education programme is the Green Schools Programme (GSP) by Delhi-based think tank Centre for Science and Environment. Under GSP, students carry out a comprehensive environmental audit of their school campus. They understand how resource-efficient their school is by delving into its water consumption and conservation, waste management, green area, food habits, energy efficiency, and much more. They interact with members of the school as well as the local community and understand their challenges through the lens of environmental conservation. The audit is done every year, allowing students

Miyawaki forest area – before

to see the cumulative impact of small changes year-on-year. The exercise seems daunting, but is broken down into sections, with each section having a set of small hands-on activities. When these activities and discussions enter the classroom, there is space for children to actively construct knowledge about sustainable resource consumption. Since this knowledge is embedded in their immediate context, it has the potential to cause a shift in how the students see the world. This is where they acquire a new lens, i.e., of environmental conservation, through which they can now analyze the world. Children who have had such experiences in their school are better equipped to carry them to their home and larger communities.

As part of the GSP team, I recently came across a commendable example of the transformative power of environment education. Students and teachers in Zila Parishad High School Gandaboyanapalli (Anamayya, Andhra Pradesh) managed to transform a half-acre barren area of land into a lush green forest using the Miyawaki forest method. Their most remarkable achievement, however, was not the transformation of the land itself – it was how the school brought together teachers, students, community members, forest department officials, and a local NGO for a common cause. The NGO provided financial aid, while the forest department helped with saplings suitable to the area. Community members also dedicated their time towards nurturing the plants. This joint effort beautifully illustrates the power that a dedicated community holds. The transformed land is now a classroom in itself – students gather there regularly to observe wildlife, water plants, and gather horticulture waste for composting. One can only imagine the insights that students might be taking away through such an experience.

Programmes like GSP highlight the scope of integration of environment education with existing curricula. Simple hands-on activities that push students to question their daily activities can be a part of all classrooms – be it mathematics or business studies. An honest effort on the teachers' part can go a long way in ensuring such an integration. For instance, mensuration is a part of all grade 6 mathematics classrooms, where children learn different units and methods of measurement. Instead of learning about them theoretically, why not encourage children to measure the window-to-floor ratio of their classroom? The discussion can then take a brief detour into proper ventilation and air quality. Similarly, water wastage is a theme covered in most grade 7 science classrooms. The teacher can guide students to conduct a simple water audit of their school and detect leaks or other sources of wastage. Presenting such findings to the school administration would not only help manage the water resource better, but also build students' conviction in their voice as changemakers.

As the climate crisis worsens, children cannot be passive observers of a jeopardized future. They must be active participants in the conversations around mitigating and responding to the climate crisis. Their voices must not only be heard, but valued and amplified. For this, the onus falls on our teachers and classrooms. The rote learning that has characterized our classrooms since colonial times needs to be replaced with a participatory classroom discourse that is rooted in a shared concern for the planet. Without the necessary skills to navigate a climate-risked world, we risk pushing our children into a world they can neither understand nor predict. Action-oriented climate education is our best bet to empower children to negotiate their existence on the rapidly warming planet.

& after

Rooted in the past, evolving for the future

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School is a platform that shapes minds, teaches values, and builds the citizens of tomorrow. Education in India used to be more than just books and exams. It was about shaping character, building life skills, and nurturing values. Long before the modern classrooms and school bells, there was the gurukul system – a beautiful way of learning where students lived with their guru, learning not just lessons from the scriptures but also life lessons. This system emphasized holistic development, moral values, and practical skills alongside academic learning.

Today, while our school hours are structured between 8 am and 3 pm and the curriculum is tightly defined, the *essence* of the gurukul system still lingers. Several modern-day residential and alternative schools in India – like Rishi Valley School in Andhra Pradesh or Sahyadri School in Maharashtra – embrace holistic education grounded in community living and value-based learning. And this is an ideology that I believe all schools can follow – take the essence of the gurukul system and mould it to suit the modern times.

Illustration: Shilpy Lather

Role of institutions

I have noticed students feel disconnected from their school environment due to stress, peer pressure, and performance anxiety. This highlights the need for schools to go beyond academics and focus on inclusion, emotional support, and student wellbeing. With student-centred learning, access to learning support, inclusive learning practices, and active involvement of parents this can be achieved.

'Children must be taught how to think, not what to think.'
– Margaret Mead

Lofty ideas of change might appear appealing, but profound impact comes from the smallest of actions.

The morning assembly constitutes the prayer, news, other presentations, and the national anthem. The significance of our culture should be reiterated in the assembly. Simple acts like greeting the teachers and thanking the service staff have to be encouraged. Students must keep their classrooms clean.

On the academic front, the choice of second language has led to a lot of debate among the parent community. Mother tongue has been made mandatory in many states. A large amount of money is spent on learning foreign languages, but there is reluctance to learn Indian languages. This should change. We should take pride in Indian languages.

'A good teacher can inspire hope, ignite the imagination, and instil a love of learning.' – Brad Henry

In a world driven by technology, where information is available in milliseconds, what makes the teacher irreplaceable?

It's their human connection. Educators have a key role to play in the lives of their students. Even though content is available at the click of a button, the role of teachers cannot be negated. The methods of teaching could vary, but the desire is the same – overall development of the student. The class teacher can make an anecdotal record of each student, which gives an insight into the family background, hobbies, difficult subjects, or any other problems the student faces. Another area that demands attention is emotional safety. According to a 2022 *India School Safety Report*, nearly 50% of students across urban schools report experiencing bullying in some form. This reinforces the urgent need for schools to implement strong anti-bullying policies, backed by peer support groups and trained mental health counsellors.

As educators, if we can instil confidence and help our students overcome such challenges, it will reap wonderful results. Everyone wants to be heard; some are upfront, while others may need a push. As educators we have to keep a sharp eye on the behaviour of our students. Small steps can do wonders.

Apart from teaching, a teacher must inspire. They must open the minds of their students to dream big. They must expose students to the countless opportunities that await them. Teachers help students realize what their dreams and aspirations are and help them take the first steps in their careers. Real learning is fun, and this is what every teacher must promote. Students should be exposed to real-world applications of the concepts they learn, so that they appreciate what they learn and gain a sense of respect and admiration for the topics taught.

Teenage years are an especially turbulent phase of life. The teacher must try to understand their teenage students and what they are going through. They need to be the pillar that their students can fall back on.

The other challenge faced by educators is to engage the students actively. Teachers should be prepared with five-minute games like TCS – tap, clap, and snap, where students can follow instructions. Vocabulary games pique curiosity. They break the monotony of the class and act like brain teasers. Guess the word, give the antonym and synonym, word ladder, and fill in with vowels are some games that can be played in the classroom to engage students. Teaching a math concept on the football ground or through cooking and science through hands-on activities will spark student interest. In social studies, the exercise of the model United Nations will expose students to myriad issues around the world. Interaction with farmers and understanding the process of harvesting and how they manage the sales of products is a perfect way to connect with reality. Another learning strategy is cooperative learning, which involves group discussion, group projects, and dramatization. This facilitates sharing of ideas, teamwork, appreciation of members in a group, and acceptance of different perspectives. *Education World India School Rankings 2023* highlighted that schools that adopted interdisciplinary and real-world application models showed a 15-20% higher student engagement rate compared to traditional rote-learning institutions.

Transformation doesn't happen in a day. It is a gradual process. Tapping students' potential is vital to boost their confidence. We must remember that every child is special and our job is to create an environment in which they will flourish. This is why we need to go back to how we started our learning journey; we need to find our way back to the gurukul system.

TP

It's (not) just a piece of paper!

Untextbooking and *artifying* learning resources

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Isn't the act of opening or "unboxing" something – a gift, a box of sweets, a hamper, or a utility appliance – a memorable experience? Even in an overtly digital era, the eagerness and joy of receiving a new game box or simply opening a pack of crayons is unparalleled. As stretched as it may sound at first, I have embarked on a lofty mission to contrast this sensory, tactile experience with the pervasive "textbook" and the broader ambit of learning, in the hope of disrupting the presentation and delivery of curricula in educational discourse. The tool? The ubiquitous paper and a little creativity!

The textbook trap

As a student in a regular state board school, I, like many others, despised the drab, lacklustre textbooks that were the centrestage of every classroom, year after year. My interest in art and craft made matters worse, making the text-heavy design, basic illustrations, or cover art underwhelming in both appearance and appeal. They seemed rigid and uninspiring, yet authoritative!

Three aspects need reflection here. First, to recognize that the design and value of the textbook has been a matter of long-standing review. As succinctly put by Harrison et al (2022)[1], (commercial) textbooks are "unable to be updated, reworded, or otherwise altered" by teachers. It is equally noteworthy that many teachers find themselves compelled to transmit the exact content and that it is hardly packaged in or accompanied by innovative pedagogical tools. Secondly, to quote Kimmons (2015)[2], "Teachers must make their students malleable to the content rather than make the content malleable to their students." These and several other limitations, in fact, fuelled the open educational resource (OER) movement, ideas such as of open pedagogy[3] as also alternative learning avenues such as open courseware (MIT's OCW[4] being an eloquent example) since the 2000s. Thirdly, any pedagogical intervention, be it through an OER or teacher-introduced design, needs to present opportunities for learner-centric, modular, and customizable learning. For this to happen, the textbook must be deprioritized, or, in many a recent educational reform, become "untextbooked"[5,6]. The third aspect is especially important for STEM subjects, particularly environmental science, sustainability, and geography, which, despite their real-world interfaces and dynamically updating content, get trapped within the confines of a textbook, whose updation is time-taking and challenging. Clearly, their "packaging" begs more attention and innovation, if their learning is expected to translate into meaningful impact!

Purposeful paper

We often take the humble paper for granted, and understandably so! After all, from being a cornerstone in the history of humankind, paper has come a long way in occupying such a commonplace in our lives. The same paper that makes documents legal also helps us in our first steps of literacy – as somewhere to write on and read from. The paper that can take us around the world through colourful fold-out maps and newspapers is also the same material that our textbooks are printed on and firmly bound. Through an artistic lens, paper is the delight of the painter, printmaker, and crafter.

The reliance on paper in education also reflects a spectrum – from teacher handouts, notebooks, reference books, the notorious "test papers", theses to craft projects involving paper, beautiful works of poster art adorning school walls, and much more. The tactile paper, despite stiff competition from the digital world and ideas of altogether digitized classrooms, seems like it's still here to stay. Is there value in reimagining it for education, to reinstate a sense of wonder, curiosity, and stimulation? Can this very paper literally and metaphorically help "deconstruct" or "unbound" the textbook, and at the same time preserve a unique bridge between the digital and the analog (physical)? Finally, could the underrated paper inspire teachers to contemplate what they seek to teach and how they teach it in new, creative ways... perhaps complementing the textbook if not immediately doing away with it or going all-out digital? Four cases-in-point elucidate some approaches in this direction.

Not entirely a paper paradigm

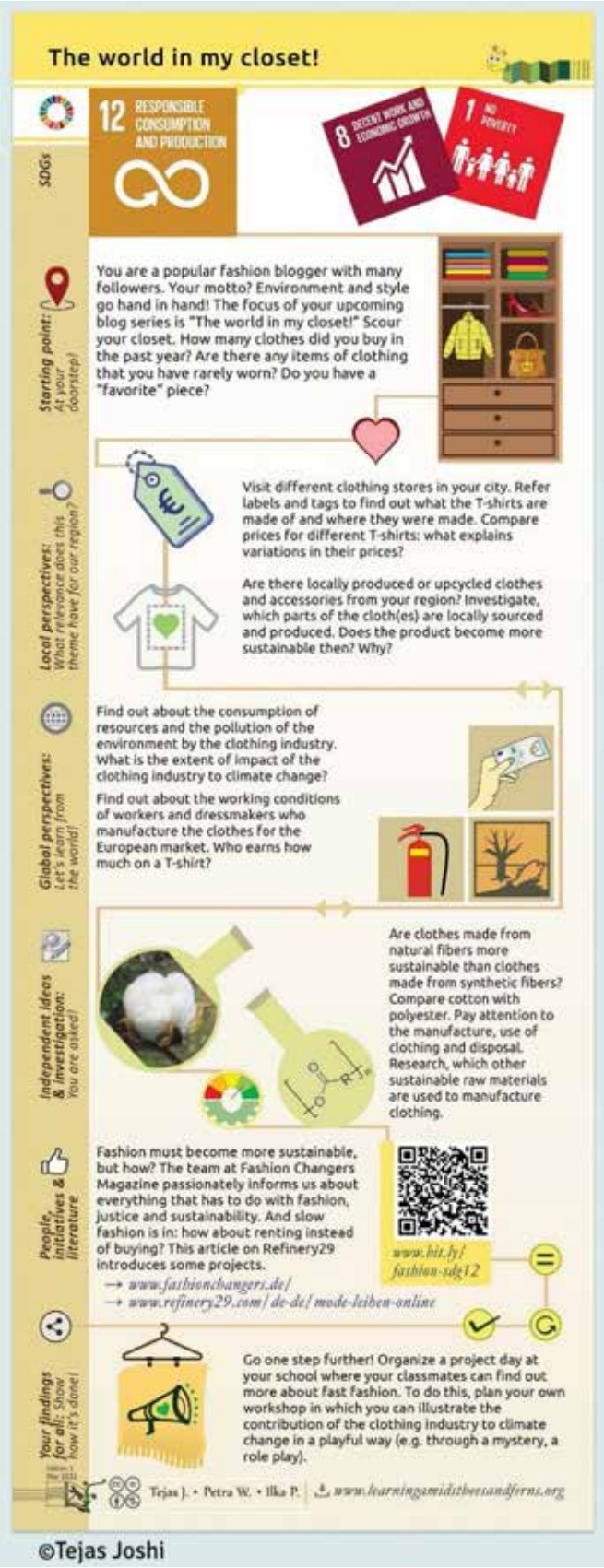
Cards of various sorts illustrate an easy detour from the book format and are tangible for teachers and learners alike. Be it flashcards, information cards, playing cards on thematic subjects (often rooted in entertainment-based card games), activity cards, card prompts/quiz cards, or quick response (QR)-linked cards leading to further (digital) media/repositories, cards have offered myriad possibilities as pedagogical facilitators. Inherently modular, versatile, and at times messy, the sky is the limit in thinking of the pedagogic utility of cards whilst still relying on a palm-sized set of papers.

Worldwide, innumerable card-based resources on practically all subjects are on offer, even though they have not been as widely disseminated as their bound competitors. In India, except for a few publishers and outreach materials (e.g., field guides by the Bombay Natural History Society or my previous work on the chemical elements[7]), card-based tools are still considered niche and are plagued by high costs with low incentivization, mainstreaming, and limited design ingenuity. The important perspective here is whether we can move beyond perceiving this medium as a mere pedagogical aid and as a place for embedding current (updated) curricular content. A repository of visual, anecdotal module-based resources on relevant contextualized content, coupled with elaborate but flexible facilitatory handouts could open new ways of diversifying curricula through rich, co-curricular topics.

Infographic 1 provides a snapshot of two such projects spanning complexity and themes. Even the facilitatory activity handouts have great design potential, for instance collections from the successful Process Oriented Guided Inquiry Learning (POGIL) technique[8] provide inspiration. Aside from their small footprint, cards and related formats such as posters and infographics starkly differ from the bound textbook being easily customizable and reprintable (with accessible web tools like Canva[9] and Visme[10]), yet retaining their physical flexibility and form. With thoughtful design intervention, support, and impetus from national education providers, such cards can potentially constitute some of the accompanying "kickstarters" for a new term, year, or class.

Images courtesy: Tejas Joshi

Infographic 1: Snapshots of two card-centric learning resources (Left: "Let's Meet the Chemical Elements!" (Joshi, T., & Ladage, S.) Right: "Biodiversity Advocates! (Joshi, T.)



Infographic 2: An exemplar SDG impulse card on slow fashion (Joshi, T., Wlotzka, P., & Parchmann, I.)

Posing questions or imposing information

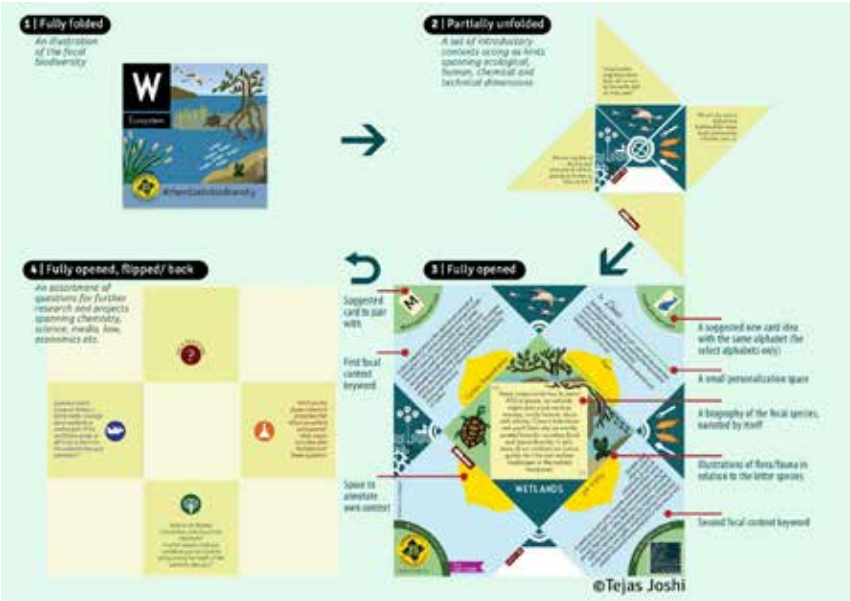
In the course of history, one of the greatest accomplishments with the advent of paper was its ability for record-keeping, documentation, and spreading information: functioning as a "proof" or authentic source of knowledge. For better and for worse, textbooks or conventional books continue to perpetuate this norm. Can they be perceived or suited as sites to ask questions or guide pursuits of learner-led discourses? To some proponents, this would almost imply challenging the identity and authority of the textbook. In one of our projects (Joshi, Wlotzka & Parchmann, 2019[11]), we set out to redress this limitation for introducing the teaching of the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)[12] by devising a super-compact range of "SDG Impulse Cards". The resource, symbolized by the logo of a caterpillar, is visual, palpable and "directly speaks to the user" by posing questions rather than feeding ready-made knowledge – thereby allowing for an array of class or informal project opportunities.

Designed in the form of an accordion that folds into an almost finger-sized fan (Refer Infographic 2 and 4), each impulse card has a common anchoring framework and comprises questions or stimuli for users to independently engage with individual, local, and global considerations, and gradually learn science topics via competences and actions (solutions) towards ambitious goals. The material by itself may be diminutive, yet it straddles themes of global relevance and aims at ultimately leading to changemaking by stepping into the shoes of varied professions and getting a sense of what it takes to find answers to not-so-easy questions. Infographic 2 showcases an impulse card themed on slow fashion[13].

Puzzling paper

If there is one art technique that does justice to paper, it would undoubtedly be the elegant origami. Whilst origami continues to be widely practiced within and outside education and its benefits are well-appreciated[14], could it provide cues for the design of sophisticated paper-centred learning resources? Also worth considering is whether animations and scaffolding are only the forte of digital media like videos and interactive animation/ web tools, or if we can exploit the versatility of the paper slightly further. A rendition of such a concept is the project "Chemtastic Biodiversity!", a new learning resource to learn chemistry from, with and for biodiversity. Envisaged within the traditional Victorian fold technique, an intricate yet sturdy multi-fold mechanism that allows for an "unfurling"

process akin to a puzzle, with strategically placed keywords, contexts, and guiding questions interspersing with visuals. Infographic 3 walks through the basic mechanism and visual affordances of its design; feel welcome to explore and interpret it for yourself!



Infographic 3: A digitized depiction of the folding mechanism of the resource "Chemtastic Biodiversity!" (Joshi,. T.)

Old and new

This article is a sheer attempt to reinterpret paper, not simply as a material but as a credible means to artify learning media for introducing real-world contexts/ topics in education without solely relying on curricular or textbook reform. Paper can be perceived as an authoritative tool for knowledge distribution – just like how it has been used – but also be creatively remodelled (albeit in small ways to begin with) for fostering uniquely immersive, memorable constructivist epistemologies. Could libraries of such materials, of course integrated with the rich affordances of the web, come together, and eventually decommission the textbook in the form of a composite "box of wonders" as an advent into the new year?

Infographic 4: Contents of the "Future Scientist's Toolkit", originally in German as "Das Future Forscher*in Toolkit" (Joshi, T.)

Such a concept has already gained promising traction with some of the above-outlined resources packed into the "Future Scientist's Toolkit"[15]. Underpinned by ideas, questions, and possibilities towards realizing education for sustainable development, this toolkit made its way into schools, informal learning avenues, district supervisors, and teacher educators as part of a ministry-led pilot dissemination in the German state of Schleswig-Holstein (see Infographic 4). Can teachers and learners design and package their own bespoke kits, acquire and explore knowledge through these materials, and go on to exchange them widely as their own works of art?

In my humble perspective, the quintessential paper is at the confluence of human ingenuity, art, communication, and sustainability. Instead of heaping advert-laden lifestyle magazines, dusty answer books, or the umpteen wasteful ways in which paper products abound, a nifty learning resource may perhaps go a long way in posing big questions, triggering food-for-thought and finding answers to the great challenges of our time.

Within the realm of education and beyond, that piece of paper lying next to you has a lot more potential than in its present form. How would you like to reimagine it as a parent, teacher, learner, creator, or educator? Making a case for rethinking paper in a hyper-digitized world might seem retrograde to many, and whether such timid, pocket-sized resources can dethrone their contemporary – the textbook – is a bigger question. Even if some ideas and concepts in this piece appear fantastical at first glance, imagination knows no bounds!

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TP

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A teacher's journey

Breaking stereotypes, empowering students

What does it really take to change how young people see the world – and themselves? Can it begin with the quiet courage of a teacher who dares to ask, "why not?" instead of waiting for policy level changes or reform in the education system?

When we talk about transformation in the education system, we often think about big reforms, changes in government rule, or policies, or systemic changes. But real change can start in small ways: a regular classroom, a simple question, or a teacher quietly determined to try something new.

I would like to share with you the story of Prashant Kumar Bhola, a teacher working in a government secondary school in a remote village of Puri in Odisha. This is a co-educational school, where most of the students come from marginalized communities and stay in hostels as their parents tend to migrate for livelihood opportunities. These students carry dreams along with pressure from their families, which is generally getting married early for the girls and start earning to support their families for the boys, and school is just a medium to get a certificate. In such an environment, how can a teacher single-handedly challenge deeply-rooted stereotypes and open new doors of possibilities?

Instead of restricting himself to teaching the students chapters of science in the classroom, Prashant sir chose to take a different approach to teaching. He first decided to bring about a shift in the mindset of his students. Prashant sir was aware that in order to do so, he would have to challenge stereotypes.

Challenging stereotypes – one act at a time

One day, Prashant sir walked into the classroom wearing nail polish. When he showed up with painted

Illustrations: Shilpy Lather

nails, there was absolute silence in the classroom, followed by curious stares and giggles. Instead of scolding the students, he calmly asked them a question:
"Why do you think nail polish is only for women? Who told us that? And does it matter?"

From there, a lively discussion blossomed. Boys and girls began to share what they have been always told like pink colours are for girls and blue for boys, how girls should focus on learning household chores so they can stay happily in their husband's house while boys have to focus on their studies so they can start earning soon. The teacher gently guided them to see how these beliefs are deeply rooted in them, how they never felt like questioning such beliefs that limit their choices, creating unfairness and preventing them from expressing themselves.

Even small actions send a strong message; it's important to question stereotypes, even if it is not allowed.

Prashant sir didn't stop there. He continued to nurture the curiosity he had sparked, urging students to keep questioning their beliefs. In order to launch the Gender Ideathon-Hackathon (where students solve local gender-related problems with a tech-based solution), Prashant sir arrived to school riding a "pink ladies' bicycle". It became the talk of the school. Some students laughed, some were utterly shocked, but all were intrigued.

The goal was to challenge students' ideas about colours, objects, or behaviours that are supposed to belong to one gender, and not to be funny. Through this action, Prashant sir wanted to show that men, women, and everyone beyond these binary labels should be free to express themselves, pursue their interests, and make choices without being pressurized by the society.

Talking about real-life gender roles

Education becomes powerful when it connects to students' lived realities. In one of his sessions, Prashant sir began a conversation about how stereotypes influence education and career decisions, especially for girls. He asked the students:
"Do you think girls and boys get equal freedom in choosing their careers in your families? Are girls encouraged to become engineers, scientists, or police officers? Or do people say some jobs are not for them?"

Gradually, students shared their stories. Girls talked about being discouraged from pursuing science because it was considered "too difficult" or "boy's subject". Some said they were asked to focus on learning home management skills to get a "suitable groom". The most girls were allowed was to become teachers because it would help them balance their family and work. Boys admitted that they were sometimes teased for liking art, music, or literature.

Witnessing his students open up, Prashant sir spoke candidly about his own experiences. He told them how he and his wife share all responsibilities at home – from earning money to cooking meals and managing household finances to chores even when relatives and family members question them – "Why do you cook dinner if your wife can do it?" I ask them, "Why not? We are partners. We help each other. That's how it should be."

Such honest conversations made a deep impression on the students. They began to see gender roles as choices, not rigid rules. They started to question norms they might previously have accepted without thought.

Empowering students to become problem solvers

Rather than focusing only on having conversations, Prashant sir's approach was about action.

He took these conversations beyond discussions and invited the students to think like innovators. Together, they explored different challenges that girls face in choosing careers, especially the lack of information and options and support available to them.

Social norms, limited exposure, and a lack of career guidance led to this problem. Out of this brainstorming, came the idea of developing a mobile app to support students, especially girls, in finding careers – a digital tool that could offer timely guidance and information, and connect them with mentors. The students worked on designing the app by sketching the app's pages, mapped out user journeys, and listed features they thought would be useful for them as users themselves, such as information about different job markets, professions, contact points for guidance counsellors, etc. This exercise was about a lesson in empathy, design thinking, and social change.

Through such projects, Prashant sir helped his students learn about solving real-life problems. His students started to see themselves as capable of creating change which has helped boost their confidence.

Building a culture of conversation

The most profound impact of this teacher's work is the culture he is building within the classroom.

Students are encouraged to question, debate, and share perspectives and personal stories. Discussions in the classroom are not dominated by the teacher's voice.

This culture of respectful dialogue fosters trust and understanding. Students learn that it's a safe space to express themselves, admit their problems, and challenge each other's ideas. These skills go far beyond school, they help create resilient communities when people come together to solve complex problems.

Change at school, change beyond

We often believe that change should be massive to be meaningful and impactful. But in this one school, small acts are planting seeds for systemic transformation:

- Wearing nail polish by a male teacher sparked conversation about gender norms.
- A male teacher riding a pink bicycle to school challenged stereotypes about masculinity.
- Talking about personal experiences of sharing household responsibilities modelled equality in everyday life.
- Identifying problems students faced to choose their career pathways and designing a mobile app gave students a vision of how technology can drive social change.
- Encouraging open dialogue in the classroom transformed how students engage with each other and with learning.

These changes ripple outward. Students carry new ideas home and outside. They begin to ask their parents questions. Other students start showing interest. Other teachers become curious.

A small change that starts in a single classroom can spread across an entire school and perhaps, in time, into the wider education system.

A call to imagine

So, if you want to change something in education, start by imagining how it would look inside your own school. What would you like to see shift? Would it transform how things normally work? What new possibilities could it create for students?

Or think back: have you ever been part of a change in your school that altered the classroom environment or how the school functions? It might have been something as seemingly small as learning how to talk and listen to each other. Such shifts create deeper understanding, stronger relationships, and communities better equipped to tackle challenges together.

Or it might be a bigger systemic change – like transforming how children are assessed, or making sure every child, regardless of gender or background, feels seen, heard, and supported.

The story of this educator shows us that change does not always need grand programems or vast resources. Sometimes, it starts with a simple question:
"Why not?"

And sometimes, it starts with a teacher who dares to wear nail polish to school.

Before I ended my conversation with him, I asked Prashant sir if he ever felt worried about how people might judge him for doing all this – riding a pink bicycle, wearing nail polish, or talking so openly about gender and equity. He smiled and said:
"Of course, I get scared sometimes. But then I ask myself – 'if I don't do it, who will?' Someone has to start. If I can help even one student think differently or feel more confident, isn't it worth it? And who knows, maybe one day, these students will become the teachers who change things even more than I ever could."

So, I will leave you with this same question Prashant sir asks his students and himself every day – *Why not start the change with you?*

TP

Steering a 'U' turn

How a Malayalam film inspired change in our classrooms

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For Malayalam cinema, the year 2024 was a gold mine. Kerala's film industry catapulted to national attention when movies like *Manjummel Boys, Aavesham,* and *Premalu* achieved box office success across the country. Filmmakers were lauded for unique storylines and cost-effective production, and actors for their natural performances.

In the treasure trove of those Malayalam films, was another film, albeit a smaller one. The film was small only in terms of budget, star cast, and box office numbers; the film made it big when it came to intention and impact. That film was *Sthanarthi Sreekuttan*, director Vinesh Viswanath's debut feature film, which was released in theatres in November last year.

The story is set in an upper primary school in Karettu, a village in the southern part of Kerala. *Sthanarthi* translates to candidate, and *Sreekuttan* is the name of one of the four protagonists of the film, all of whom are children. The title of the film refers to Sreekuttan's candidature for the class leader post, and showcases his desperate strategies to make a winning attempt. Sreekuttan is a member of the back-bencher gang and a notorious latecomer, whereas his competitor, Ambadi, is a disciplined, studious boy who has a special place in the front row of the class and the class-teacher's heart.

This film came to national attention after one shot from its climax made some teachers in Kerala rethink a tradition, leading to action, which resonated outside the borders of Kerala.

Images courtesy: Saina Play & Budget Lab Productions

One visual, big impact

What is that climactic shot which effected a perspectival change? The traditional classroom system of arranging benches and desks in rows is shown to be overturned to make way for a U-shape, thus axing the hierarchy of students based on front-bencher / back-bencher labels.

During its theatrical release in November last year, the film didn't get to ride the wave of appreciation. But once it was released on the streaming platform Saina Play, in late June 2025, it started making ripples. Albert Christin, one of the seven teachers at RCC L.P. School, East Mangad, in Kerala's Thrissur district, was among the first who sat up and noticed. "He urged the rest of us to watch the film, and once we did, we were in agreement about implementing a change," says Liji C.R., Albert's colleague and the headmistress of the school.

They tried out the new system in class 1 and sensed an instant shift in children's temperament. For small children, Liji says, proximity to their teacher is an emotional matter. Without benches, desks, and other students adding to the distance, the new system ensured that teachers were in close quarters with all students, equally. There were noticeably fewer tantrums. This inspired the teachers to adopt the system in the other six classrooms too.

Once RCC L.P. School posted visuals of the new layout of their classrooms on Instagram and made the film's director a collaborator on the post, the idea garnered a lot more eyeballs. Many more schools in Kerala, like St. Mary's English Medium School, Konni; St. Thomas L.P. School, Arthat; Pappinisseri West L.P. School, Kannur; Ramavilasom Vocational Higher Secondary School, Valakam; followed suit, all without any state directive. The wave soon crossed Kerala borders. On July 13 this year, A. Ragu Raman reported in the Times of India that the Tamil Nadu state education department has directed all its chief educational officers to pilot the system of arranging benches and desks in the shape of the Tamil letter 'Pa'.

Priyanjali Narayan wrote on India Today that this "quiet, but growing shift" is happening in states like Punjab and West Bengal too. Back in Kerala, the minister for education, V. Sivankutty set up an expert committee to look into a suitable model for the state's education system, "one that may include eliminating the concept of backbenchers" – reported The News Minute.

What changes, really?

It is now roughly two months since this was implemented at RCC L.P. School, and Liji is elated about the impact. "Parents of today are much more protective and ambitious about their kids. Nobody wants their kids to be backbenchers in class. With this arrangement, parents couldn't be happier. For children too, the setting gives an equal opportunity, and it is especially beneficial for the reticent and the introverted. Of course, the mischievous ones can no longer get distracted or indulge in other businesses, because everyone is now in the 'line of fire' potentially. But isn't that a good thing?" she asks buoyantly.

She adds that her school has students from economically backward communities. The students are smart and participate in classrooms actively, but most of them do not have a conducive learning atmosphere back home. This reflects in their performance in examinations, and the only way to resolve this problem is to give them the most attention in the school itself, in the most inclusive manner. There is no doubt that when children are seated in a semi-circular pattern, with the teacher standing in the centre, the class becomes more engaged with more scope of interaction between them. Not to forget, the teachers' job has become much easier with this shift. Especially in lower primary classes where it has to be ensured that children write down everything, this system gives more visibility of not just the students, but their notebooks too.

But there is a subtler mindset shift involved in this whole revamp, an idea that is conveyed strongly in the film. The film's protagonists are all children, as mentioned

Image courtesy: Ashik Babu & Budget Lab Productions

earlier; but the antagonist is a teacher. The character Chakrapani (called CP), brought to life by actor Aju Varghese, is everything that a teacher should not be: unscrupulous, arrogant, and megalomaniac. He favours the studious and smart Ambadi excessively, often berating other students in the process. There is one particular scene where he makes the back-bencher gang shift to the front bench, and then belittles them by asking them to move back after a public dressing-down. Stirring divisiveness by connecting students' capacities and capabilities to where they are seated in the classroom is a theme that runs through the film, causing distress to the protagonists.

It is in this context, that the one fleeting visual at the end of the film, where the benches and desks are rearranged in a more inclusive shape, becomes powerful. In one stroke, there are no more back-benchers, front-benchers, or the hierarchy that comes with it.

The power of an idea

The director of the film *Sthanarthi Sreekuttan* says that this is not a new idea; it is common in Scandinavian countries like Norway and Finland. Vinesh himself sat in a semi-circular seating arrangement while he was a class 3 student in Govt. L.P. School, Pedikulam. It was the era of DPEP – the District Primary Education Programme – a national project launched in 1993 to achieve universalization of elementary education. He remembers the seating system as more engaging from a student perspective, but for various reasons, it did not last.

Vinesh, who is also one of the writers of the film, is jubilant that the film has sparked this conversation now. He says, "We received some flak from people saying the idea is not practical in classrooms with large student strength. We agree. But the point is that no classroom should have more than 30 students ideally, to ensure that all students receive the attention they deserve. There was also criticism that students should be able to see the blackboard in a straight line, and this seating arrangement will result in a sub-optimal angle of vision. But this is a perspective that comes from the thought that classroom teaching should be blackboard centred. It is high time we moved away from that. Also, it is possible to have place-rotation even in the semi-circular pattern. Despite these disagreements, we are overjoyed that our little film is the reason why this discussion ensued."

On social media, it is not uncommon to see content around the nostalgia of having been back-benchers, how they are the ones who make it big later in life, etc. But Vinesh objects without hesitation: "No student who has been discriminated against for being a back-bencher will ever romanticize that idea. I was a back-bencher right up to college because of my height, and I have witnessed this discrimination first-hand. Being ignored isn't an experience anybody deserves, let alone children."

All of the situations and sub-plots visualized in the film have been derived from the personal experiences of the four writers: Murali Krishna, Anand Manmadhan (also an actor in the film), Kailash S. Bhavan (also the editor of the film) and Vinesh Viswanath (the director). Vinesh speaks on all their behalf: "All of us have had teachers with traits of CP in varying intensities. It is such toxicity that should be questioned. So, what really matters is not just the seating arrangement; it is the mindset around it, of the society at large and teachers in particular."

There is no doubt that this small film has induced a silent movement, criticism notwithstanding. For the makers of the film, it was a sweet surprise that this idea was adopted voluntarily by various schools and the state too; it is not something they foresaw or even hoped for. If there is one takeaway for teachers from this, it is that small ripples too can bring about impactful change, and often, those start within us. U / C / V in English or Pa in Tamil – whatever name you call it, the one shape that truly matters is the shape of our thinking.

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